

The Dragon Glass Map

The Adventures of Elizabeth and Scarlet - Book One

A clean reading edition prepared while premium chapter illustrations are in production.

Two princess detectives. One baby dragon. A map no one was supposed to find.

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The Race Through the Great Hall

Elizabeth and Scarlet were ten-year-old princesses, which meant that everyone in the Royal Castle expected them to walk slowly, speak in complete and thoughtful sentences, and under absolutely no circumstances whatsoever slide across the marble floor in roller skates.

Unfortunately for everyone, the marble floor was perfect for roller skates.

It shone like a frozen lake under the tall, arched windows of the Great Hall, so polished and pale it made you feel like you could skate clear to the horizon without ever having to pick up your feet. Sunlight poured through the stained glass panels high in the walls and painted the floor in shifting pools of red, blue, and gold. When Elizabeth tilted her head just right, it looked like they were skating through a kaleidoscope.

Scarlet, naturally, had already strapped hers on.

She stood at the far end of the hall in her red roller skates, one hand braced against the wall, one knee bent like she was born at a starting line. Her auburn hair fanned behind her like a battle flag. She had the exact look she always got before a bad idea — shining eyes, enormous grin, absolutely no caution whatsoever.

Elizabeth held her own skates in her hands. She looked at the hall. She looked at Scarlet. She looked at the row of ancestors frowning down at her from their gilded portrait frames.

"This," she said, "is going to end badly."

"Everything ends badly," Scarlet said cheerfully. "That's how you know it was worth doing."

"That is not wisdom. That is a T-shirt."

"Fine." Scarlet straightened up and patted her knee. "But no pushing. And no screaming. And no crashing into royal things." Elizabeth sat on the bench at the hall's edge and began lacing her skates. Her fingers moved steadily. She always did this — thought it through while Scarlet was already halfway into the disaster.

"You make it sound like I crash into royal things all the time," Scarlet said.

Elizabeth did not look up. "Last week you crashed into a suit of armor and apologized to it."

"It looked offended."

"It was armor, Scarlet. Armor cannot look offended."

"This armor could." Scarlet paused, apparently reconsidering. "It had very expressive shoulder plates."

Elizabeth stood up, tested her weight on the skates, and immediately felt the marble pull her forward like it had been waiting for her specifically. That was the thing about good intentions in roller skates — the floor didn't care about them at all.

"Fine," she said. "But we go to the Pedestal Room door and back. No detours. No spiraling into furniture. No victorious whooping that alerts the household staff."

"I would never whoop victoriously."

"Last Tuesday."

"That," Scarlet said with great dignity, "was a triumphant exclamation."

They took their positions at the far end of the hall, crouched at the strip of morning sunlight that fell diagonally from the first eastern window. It was as perfect a starting line as the castle could offer.

"One," Elizabeth said.

"Two," Scarlet said.

"Thr—"

They launched.

The marble sang under their wheels. The sound was low and smooth, a hum that vibrated up through Elizabeth's ankles and into her knees, and she leaned forward the way you had to if you wanted speed instead of just noise. Her braid flipped back over her shoulder. Their capes — they hadn't planned to be wearing capes, but royal mornings had a way of beginning with capes — snapped behind them like the wings of startled birds.

They flew past the portrait gallery. The ancient kings and queens of the realm stared down at them with the collective expression of people who had very strongly wished, while they were alive, that someone would invent a rule against children.

Scarlet took the lead first. She always did. She was running on pure joy and no brakes, and she hit a long patch of un-textured marble and went even faster, laughing so hard her whole body shook, which was absolutely not a stable way to maintain speed on polished stone. Elizabeth leaned into it, caught up, and they glided side by side past the second alcove, past the suit of armor that Scarlet had most certainly traumatized last week, past the blue velvet curtain that smelled like old roses and something older.

The finish line was the archway into the Pedestal Room.

The Pedestal Room was where Dad kept the things he loved most. Old maps. A brass telescope that had belonged to his grandmother. Three medals from his university years that he pretended not to be proud of and was absolutely proud of. And centered in the middle of the room on a polished column of white marble, under a glass dome that was supposed to protect it but had a small crack that no one had gotten around to fixing, stood the vase.

The vase was tall and curving and entirely blue — not one blue but seven, layered in the glass like depths of ocean, with roses painted in translucent gold around the middle that caught the light and seemed to glow from inside. It had been in the family for three hundred years. Dad called it irreplaceable. Mom called it beautiful. The castle's historical register called it a "significant cultural artifact of considerable monetary and sentimental value."

If you looked too long, the gold roses almost seemed to shift, their stems bending into little paths that never stayed in the same place twice. Dad said old glass did that sometimes. Elizabeth had never

been entirely convinced.

Scarlet called it "the blue one."

As they rounded the corner at speed — Scarlet still laughing, Elizabeth calculating the physics of stopping before the doorway — the edge of Scarlet's cape caught the edge of a runner rug that was supposed to protect the floor and was not, it turned out, protecting anything useful at all.

The rug caught.

Scarlet's skate caught.

Scarlet's entire trajectory changed.

She shot sideways with a yelp that she would later describe as a quiet sound of surprise, clipped Elizabeth's shoulder with her outstretched hand, and in the cascade that followed — arms windmilling, skates scrambling, both girls trying to correct and overcorrecting simultaneously — they hit the base of the pedestal column.

Just the softest bump, really. Less of a collision than a nudge.

It was enough.

The vase rocked.

For one single, eternal second, both girls froze completely. Elizabeth's hands came up as if she could catch it from six feet away by sheer willpower. Scarlet grabbed Elizabeth's arm and squeezed hard enough to leave marks.

The vase rocked back.

Then it rocked forward.

Then it fell.

The sound was enormous. It crashed through the morning quiet of the castle like a thunderclap, a splintering, shattering boom that seemed to bounce off every stone wall and return from every direction at once. Blue glass exploded across the marble. The fragments skittered and slid and came to rest across the entire pedestal room floor, glittering like crushed ice in the morning light, some pieces the size of a palm, others no bigger than a fingernail.

The glass dome had not protected anything except its own integrity, which had held perfectly.

Silence.

One sliver of blue glass slid across the marble and stopped against Elizabeth's skate. For a second — only a second — it glowed as if it had remembered the sunlight after the room had gone still.

Scarlet's hand came up slowly and covered her mouth.

Elizabeth stared at the empty column. At the base, where the vase had stood, a perfect circle of marble was clean and pale as bone.

"Tell me," Scarlet whispered, "that was not the vase."

Elizabeth's throat had stopped working correctly. "It was the vase."

"Tell me it was not Dad's favorite vase."

A pause. A very long one. "It was Dad's favorite vase."

They stood perfectly still. Listening. The castle seemed to be holding its breath with them, as if it too had not quite processed what had just happened. Then, from somewhere deep in the east wing, came the distant sound of footsteps.

They moved at exactly the same moment.

"We have to fix it," Scarlet said, already spinning toward the door.

"How?" Elizabeth's voice was barely audible. "It is in a million pieces."

Scarlet grabbed the hem of her cape and looked at the scattered blue glass around them. Her face had gone from horrified to determined, which was both more useful and more alarming. "Then we fix a million pieces."

They found a silk scarf in the hall closet — a long green one that normally lived around the neck of a portrait they didn't much like — and knelt on the cold marble together, gathering the largest shards with careful, shaking hands. The pieces clinked against each other with a soft musical sound, like wind chimes having a very bad day. Elizabeth's hands trembled. She was thinking about how Dad kept the vase dusted himself. How he sometimes just stood in the doorway of the Pedestal Room and looked at it the way you look at things that feel like home.

Scarlet's eyes kept darting to the doorway. "We are in so much trouble."

"Not if we fix it first."

"That," Scarlet said, "is not how trouble works."

They pushed the smallest fragments under the shelf beside the pedestal — the ones so tiny they'd never be able to reassemble them anyway — and carried the larger pieces wrapped in the silk scarf up to their bedroom, where they sat on the floor and stared at each other and then at the bundle between them, and tried very hard not to think about the fact that there was still an empty pedestal downstairs where three hundred years of history used to live.

Fixing it, Elizabeth thought, was going to require a plan.

What she didn't know yet was that fixing it was going to require something much stranger than that.

Max Makes a Deal

The knock came at 7:58 the next morning.

It was a very particular kind of knock — neat, measured, three precise raps with a single knuckle, leaving exactly the right amount of silence between each one. It was the knock of someone who had never in their life knocked too hard or too softly, and who found the idea of doing so deeply personally offensive.

Elizabeth and Scarlet looked at each other across the bedroom with the specific wordless communication that only people who have shared a room since birth can manage. It said: we are not ready. It said: act natural. It also said, quite clearly: natural is impossible right now so at least act alive.

The silk scarf full of broken glass sat on Elizabeth's bed, glittering with guilt in the morning light. They had not slept well.

"Hide it," Scarlet mouthed.

Elizabeth grabbed the scarf and shoved it under the nearest pillow as the door swung open. Max the Butler stepped in carrying a silver breakfast tray, moving with the steady, unhurried grace of someone who has been moving through castle corridors for many years and knows every creak and corner of all of them.

He wore his white suit, which he always wore, ironed with such precision you could have used it to set a compass. His polished black shoes reflected the room back at him in miniature. His curled mustache sat above his lip in perfect symmetry. And across his chest hung his rainbow tie, which should have looked ridiculous on a royal butler and somehow instead looked entirely correct, as if he had invented the concept and everyone else was merely following his lead.

He set the breakfast tray on the table with the quiet click of someone who puts things down exactly where they mean to.

"Good morning, Princesses," he said, and began uncovering the plates.

"Good morning, Max," they said, in the synchronized monotone of people trying very hard to seem as though nothing had happened.

There was a pause.

Max arranged the juice glasses. He straightened the napkins. He moved the small vase of morning flowers two centimeters to the left and then decided they were better centered and moved them back.

"You are very quiet this morning," he observed.

"We are quiet people," Scarlet said.

"You knocked over a lamp last week because you were narrating your own story too loudly."

"That was someone else."

"There is no one else in this bedroom."

"I was doing an impression."

Elizabeth, who was sitting on the edge of the bed doing her best impression of a pillow herself — small, unobtrusive, hiding the shape of the broken glass beneath her — pressed her lips together very hard to keep from laughing. This was not a laughing situation. She was simply not going to make it worse.

Max set the tray down, turned, and let his gaze travel slowly across the room. It was the kind of gaze that saw everything and pretended to be interested in nothing. He saw the pillow. He saw the slight irregularity in its shape. He saw the corner of something blue peeking out from beneath it, catching the morning light in a way that morning light catching silk did not.

For the smallest part of a second, the blue corner reflected in his polished shoe like a tiny map of lightning. Max went very still. Then he became Max again, which meant he became even stiller, but on purpose.

His expression did not change.

"Princesses," he said, "is there something you would like to tell me?"

"No," Scarlet said.

"Maybe," Elizabeth said, at exactly the same time.

They looked at each other.

Max lifted one eyebrow. It was a very precise eyebrow lift. He had several varieties — the curious one, the skeptical one, the deeply disappointed one — and this was the one that meant he already knew but was giving them the opportunity to be honest about it, which was, in its own way, both kind and completely devastating.

Elizabeth reached under the pillow and pulled out the silk scarf. The shards shifted and clinked against each other softly, like a terrible little symphony. She set the bundle on the bed between them.

For a long moment, no one said anything.

Scarlet found her socks very interesting.

"It was an accident," Elizabeth said finally. "We were skating, and the floor was slippery, and the pedestal was too close to the corner."

"The pedestal," Max said evenly, "has been in the same spot for two hundred years."

"Then it has been too close to the corner for two hundred years and no one has mentioned it." Scarlet looked up. She knew this wasn't helping. She said it anyway.

Max looked at the scarf of glass for a long moment. Then he folded his gloved hands behind his back, which was a gesture he used when he was making a decision.

"Please wait," Scarlet said, before he could speak. "Please, Max. We'll fix it. We just need time."

"We'll do anything," Elizabeth added, and then immediately regretted it, because you did not say that to someone who had been a royal butler for as long as Max had without some sense of what exactly that

phrase was worth.

"Anything," Max repeated, and the word in his mouth sounded like something being tested for weight.

"Anything reasonable," Elizabeth said, correcting herself quickly.

A silence. The longest one of the morning.

Then Max moved to the room's small armchair, lifted the stack of Elizabeth's books off it with one hand, set them on the floor, and sat down with the deliberate ease of a man taking a meeting.

"Very well," he said. "I will keep your secret for now. No word to your father, no word to your mother. However." He held up one finger. "Tonight, during the Queen's speech, you will behave perfectly. Not approximately. Not mostly. Perfectly. No running. No whispering behind programs. No skating, no matter what. No making faces at visiting dukes, even very deserving ones. No commentary on the canapés."

Scarlet drew a breath.

"No commentary," Max said, and somehow that sentence closed every door she'd been about to open.

Elizabeth nudged Scarlet's knee beneath the breakfast tray. "We promise," Elizabeth said.

Max leaned forward slightly. It was a very small movement, but the room got more serious. "If you break this promise, I go directly to your father. Tonight, before the guests have finished their first course." He held their gaze, each in turn. "Is that understood?"

"Yes, Max," they said, in unison, in the exact tone you use when you mean it.

He stood, smoothed the front of his jacket, and moved toward the door. Then he paused with his hand on the frame, not turning back.

"Some secrets," he said, "become heavier the longer you carry them."

And he left.

The door closed with exactly the quiet click of someone who knows what doors are for.

Scarlet exhaled. It came out like she'd been holding it since the vase fell.

"Do you think he'll tell?" she asked.

"Not if we behave." Elizabeth looked at the breakfast tray. At the pancakes going cold. At the silk scarf and its cargo of broken history. "But he'll be watching."

"Can you actually behave for an entire queen's speech?"

Elizabeth thought about it honestly. She was a princess who kept promises. She had never, not once in her life, made a promise she didn't intend to keep. That was worth something, she thought. That was the kind of thing that mattered.

"For the vase," she said, "I can try."

Scarlet nodded. She picked up a pancake and folded it in half and ate it in two bites, because that was how Scarlet dealt with difficult situations. And Elizabeth opened her notebook to a fresh page, because that was how Elizabeth dealt with them, and she wrote at the top in her smallest, most careful handwriting:

Things I need to fix.

It was, so far, a very short list.

She had a feeling it was about to get longer.

The Queen's Speech and the Fifty-Dollar Treats

That evening, the castle lawn transformed into something out of a fairy tale that the fairy tale writers had put in a little extra effort on.

Hundreds of glass lanterns hung from every available anchor point — fence posts, garden stakes, the branches of the old oak trees that lined the south lawn — and as the sun went down they bloomed one by one into gold and amber light, so that the whole grounds appeared to be gently on fire in the pleasantest possible way. Ribbons of purple wisteria had been threaded through the iron railings along the terrace. Musicians stood near the fountain playing something slow and grand that you couldn't quite name but immediately felt.

Guests arrived in gleaming shoes that clicked on the stone paths, women in dresses that caught the lantern light and scattered it, men in dark jackets with medals pinned in precise rows. The air smelled of cut grass and night jasmine and the very specific scent of expensive perfume worn by people who knew it was expensive.

The Queen's speech was the biggest event of the social season, and everyone who mattered in the kingdom attended, and every one of them expected the princesses to be seated on their velvet chairs near the front, hands folded in their laps, expressions alert and pleasant, for the full duration.

Elizabeth and Scarlet had never once in their lives made pleasant expressions simultaneously for more than eleven minutes. This was a fact.

They settled into their chairs in matching ceremony dresses — Elizabeth in deep teal, Scarlet in coral — while the guests arranged themselves across the lawn on gilded chairs, and Max took his post along the wall with the household staff, his white suit a beacon in the soft light. He did not look at them. He didn't need to. They could feel his attention like a hand on their shoulders.

Scarlet smoothed her skirt with great purpose and leaned toward Elizabeth. "If the Duke of Plumford sneezes again—"

"You will say nothing," Elizabeth murmured without turning her head.

"He sneezed four times during the spring reception and each time he used a different napkin. He had a whole stack."

"He has allergies."

"He has an entire napkin collection."

Elizabeth put two fingers on Scarlet's wrist. A light touch. The signal they'd worked out years ago that meant: not now, please, for both our sakes.

The Queen stepped onto the low stone stage that the staff had built into the lawn's highest terrace, and the murmur of the crowd settled into silence with the smooth efficiency of water finding its level.

She was wearing a dress the color of the deep ocean before a storm — not quite blue, not quite grey, scattered with something that caught the lantern light and threw it back in tiny sparks, as if she'd wrapped herself in concentrated sky.

"Tonight," the Queen said, and her voice carried across the lawn with the easy authority of someone who had always been listened to and knew it, "we celebrate family. We celebrate honesty. And we celebrate the things we protect not because we must, but because they matter to us."

Elizabeth stopped breathing.

She didn't mean to. Her body simply decided, on its own, that breathing could wait.

"Our home," the Queen continued, "carries the weight of every generation that came before us and the hope of every generation still to come. The treasures we inherit are not only things. They are stories. They are the evidence that we were here, and that we cared about something enough to keep it."

Scarlet's fingers curled around the arm of her gilded chair. Elizabeth could see them, white at the knuckles, in her peripheral vision.

Across the lawn, Max remained perfectly still against the wall. The lantern light caught the edge of his rainbow tie. He did not look at the girls.

They behaved.

They did not run, or whisper, or skate, which would have been logistically complicated but not outside the realm of Scarlet's historical capabilities. Scarlet did not make a single face at the Duke of Plumford, even when he sneezed majestically into a napkin shaped like a swan and then looked at it with the expression of a man cataloguing an acquisition. Elizabeth did not fidget. She did not check the time. She did not compose lists in her head — or rather, she composed them internally, which was invisible and therefore acceptable.

When the final applause rolled across the lawn, it felt genuinely earned.

Dad appeared at their shoulders almost immediately, beaming. He had the kind of face that didn't know how to be proud quietly. "You two were incredibly patient tonight," he said, setting a hand on each of their heads. "Even the Duke noticed. He said you had exemplary poise."

"Thank you, Father," Elizabeth said.

"The Duke says that to everyone," Scarlet said, which was true but also possibly not the time.

Dad laughed. He had a large laugh, the kind that made everyone nearby smile reflexively. "Perhaps. Still. I'm proud of you both." He fished into the inside pocket of his jacket. "And patient royals deserve a proper reward. I believe the ice cream truck has been parked by the gate all evening — Julio saves a special spot for occasions like this."

He produced a crisp fifty-dollar bill and held it out.

Scarlet stared at it with the reverence of someone encountering a religious artifact.

"The speech made us very thirsty," Elizabeth said, in her most measured voice.

"Stay close to the castle gates," Dad said. "And bring back change."

"We will," Elizabeth said, taking the bill with both hands.

They walked — quickly but not quite running, because Max was still somewhere in the vicinity — toward the purple truck parked at the far end of the stone drive. It had a grinning cartoon penguin on the side holding a triple cone and a look of deep personal satisfaction. The freezer motor hummed in the warm evening air.

Julio leaned out the window. He had a beard so magnificently full it looked like a small cloud had come to rest on his face and decided to stay. He had the disposition of a man who genuinely believed he had the best job in the world, and it was very hard to argue with him.

"The princesses," he said, by way of greeting. "The usual?"

"Everything," Scarlet said, spreading her arms slightly to indicate the scope of her ambition.

They ended up with two extravagant creations. Scarlet got the Princess Special, which involved bubble-gum-flavored balls for eyes and a fondant tiara melting artfully at the top. Elizabeth got the patriot bar, striped red, white, and blue, on a stick the size of a ruler. They sat on the low stone wall along the drive while the party murmured behind them and the lanterns swayed in a gentle breeze, and the syrup stained their fingers in colors that would require explanation tomorrow.

"Behave perfectly forever," Scarlet said, licking her bubble-gum eye with philosophical solemnity. "Or fix what we broke."

Elizabeth considered her bar. "Fix what we broke."

"That sounds harder."

"It probably is."

Scarlet took a heroic bite. "We'll figure it out."

"We always do," Elizabeth agreed.

Neither of them knew, sitting there in the warm evening with sugar on their hands and lantern light on their faces, that the broken vase was not only a problem they had caused.

It was the first clue in a mystery they hadn't started looking for yet.

And mysteries, once they decide to find you, don't wait to be invited in.

Operation Ice Cream

Here is the problem with getting one really good treat: it recalibrates your entire understanding of what you deserve.

By the time Elizabeth and Scarlet were supposed to be asleep — which the castle defined as nine o'clock, though the castle's opinion on this was deeply unpopular — neither of them had come within six conversational topics of sleep. They lay in their bunks in the dark, which was doing absolutely nothing for them, listening to the sounds of the castle settling around them and thinking about, in no particular order: ice cream, the broken vase, Max's very specific eyebrow, whether the vase could actually be fixed, how much trouble they would be in if it turned out it couldn't, and also ice cream again.

"I am still hungry," Scarlet announced from the top bunk.

Elizabeth had been staring at the ceiling for forty minutes trying to read the shadows like a text and getting nothing useful out of them. "You ate two bubble-gum eyes. That is enough food to constitute a meal in some countries."

"It was dessert. Dessert does not count as food in any country."

"That is not how nutrition works."

A pause. Then: "Elizabeth."

"No."

"You don't know what I was going to say."

"You were going to say 'wouldn't it be fun if' and then describe something that would absolutely get us in trouble."

Another pause. Longer this time. "The Royal Fair coin jar," Scarlet said.

Elizabeth turned her head toward the ceiling. Last summer, at the kingdom's annual fair, they had spent an entire afternoon at the ring toss booth run by an elderly man named Gerald who was almost certainly letting them win because he'd been working with the royal household for thirty years and thought the princesses were wonderful. The prize had been a jar of gold-colored fair tokens, beautiful heavy coins embossed with the seal of the Royal Fair on one side and a smiling horse on the other, and they weren't legal tender anywhere except the fair's own grounds and, it turned out, Julio's ice cream truck.

Julio had accepted them the previous autumn with great ceremony, because he loved the Royal Fair, and because Scarlet had on that occasion helped him push his truck out of a muddy patch in the lower drive and he felt he owed her something for it.

Elizabeth sat up in the dark.

"We still have the jar," she said.

"Third shelf of the closet. Behind the craft supplies we never use."

"Scarlet."

"I know where everything is."

"Going out of the castle at night is—"

"It is a questionable mission."

"It is irresponsible."

"It is both," Scarlet said, sounding pleased with this compromise. The top bunk creaked as she leaned over the railing, her auburn hair swinging upside down, her expression in the dimness somewhere between angelic and unhinged. "Come on. We know the route. Fifteen minutes. No one will know."

"Max will know," Elizabeth said. "Max knows everything."

"Max is asleep."

"Max is never asleep. I believe Max only pretends to be human in order to better serve the household."

"Then we will be very quiet," Scarlet said, dropping back onto her mattress with a thud that suggested she had already decided. "Operation Ice Cream. Are you in or not?"

Elizabeth lay back down. She considered everything she knew about the situation: the probable consequences, the likely obstacles, the moral weight of the decision. She thought about all of this very seriously.

"Give me ten seconds," she said.

At second seven, she got out of bed.

The midnight expedition began.

They dressed in the dark — black hoodies, which Scarlet said were tactically necessary and Elizabeth said were coincidentally her only warm option — and Scarlet laced her regular shoes while Elizabeth's feet found her house slippers, which turned out to be the right call because house slippers on castle marble made almost no sound and shoes made entirely too much. Elizabeth tucked her small hand mirror into her hoodie pocket. It was useful for checking corners without putting your actual face around them. Scarlet wrapped the coin jar in a hand towel to muffle the sound of the tokens shifting.

The castle at night was a completely different place than the castle during the day.

During the day it was busy and purposeful, full of footsteps and voices and the particular domestic industry of a working royal household. At night it went quiet in a way that wasn't quite peaceful — more like held. The moonlight came in through the tall windows and turned the marble floors silver. The curtains moved when no one was near them, which was probably drafts and was nevertheless alarming. Every door, when they passed it, seemed to be listening.

Elizabeth used the mirror around three corners. Scarlet walked directly into a decorative plant on the second floor landing and had to stop and breathe very slowly for a moment and not say the word she

wanted to say. Elizabeth caught the pot before it tipped and they stood frozen for eleven seconds before confirming the corridor was still empty.

"Operation Ice Cream," Elizabeth whispered, when they reached the ground floor.

"Operation Ice Cream," Scarlet agreed, with the compressed excitement of someone trying to be inaudible about something wonderful.

They got out through the south garden door — the one with the loose latch that they had not reported to maintenance because sometimes a loose latch was a feature rather than a problem — and crossed the dark lawn toward the gate.

Julio was there.

Of course Julio was there. His truck sat at the far edge of the drive with the serving window still open, the freezer motor running, the string of little lights along the top of the truck casting gold circles on the pavement. He was leaning on the windowsill reading a book, because Julio was the kind of person who made the most of every environment.

He looked up at them with the unhurried expression of someone who had seen everything and was surprised by nothing.

"Princesses," he said.

"You saw nothing," Scarlet said, holding up the coin jar.

Julio looked at the jar. Looked at the princesses. Looked at the dark castle behind them. "Secret snack mission."

"You saw nothing," Scarlet repeated.

"I see two princesses buying ice cream at eleven forty-five at night with fair tokens." He set down his book. "What'll it be?"

They bought sundaes — enormous ones, chocolate fudge and sprinkles and a cherry each, in proper cups with real spoons, carried back across the dark lawn with the stealth of people who were moving at approximately three times their operational capacity. Elizabeth got back through the south door without incident. Scarlet hit the doorframe with her elbow but managed not to drop her cup, which was genuinely impressive under the circumstances.

They ate in the room with the lights off, sitting cross-legged on their beds, and the sundaes were the best thing either of them had ever tasted, partly because of quality and partly because of context. Midnight chocolate was simply different from afternoon chocolate. This was a scientific fact.

* * *

The next morning, Max appeared with breakfast at his customary 7:58.

He stepped through the door, set the tray on the table, and turned around.

He looked at Scarlet, who had a very small stripe of chocolate on her left cheekbone.

He looked at Elizabeth, who had a single rainbow sprinkle stuck to her chin.

He looked at the space under Scarlet's bed, where two slightly crumpled sundae cups were visible to anyone who was not actively trying to not see them.

He said nothing for a long moment. He was very good at that — at long moments that said more than speaking.

"Princesses," he said finally, in the tone of a man finding the words he needs. "We appear to have a pattern."

"A small pattern," Scarlet said.

"A sticky one," Max said, looking at the chocolate.

The punishment for Operation Ice Cream was a week of cleaning Max's butler quarters, which were immaculate and therefore required extremely precise maintenance to stay that way. They dusted his shoes in a specific order. They folded his white gloves in a specific manner. They organized his collection of rainbow ties by color, from warm to cool, in a spectrum so exacting it required a full afternoon.

Scarlet found the pineapple one on the third day.

"Why," she said, holding it up, "do you own a tie with tiny pineapples on it?"

Max accepted the tie and folded it into its place in the drawer with the same care he gave everything. "A butler," he said, "must be prepared for tropical emergencies."

Elizabeth, on her knees cleaning the baseboard by the far wall, laughed for the first time since the vase had fallen. It was a real laugh, the kind that surprised her. It felt like something loosening.

She didn't know then that the pineapple tie would matter later. In the scheme of things, it seemed like the kind of detail you'd forget.

She was wrong.

The Sky Zone Stakeout

After three days of cleaning Max's butler room — three days of shoe polish and precise fabric folding and an entire afternoon spent learning that white gloves had a correct inside-out — Scarlet announced that her body specifically required large amounts of vertical momentum to continue functioning, and that if she didn't jump on something soon she could not be held responsible for what she jumped on.

Dad, who had a gift for appearing in doorways at the exact right moment, suggested Sky Zone.

The trampoline park lived in a converted warehouse on the edge of the city, painted bright orange on the outside and filled inside with the cheerful, chaotic energy of fifty children discovering simultaneously that gravity was optional. They had been there twice before. Both times were excellent. Both times resulted in the kind of sore muscles you only get from joy.

For the first twenty minutes, it was perfect.

Scarlet invented a move she called the Royal Jellyfish, which consisted of jumping as high as possible and then going entirely boneless on the way down. It was not athletic. It was not graceful. It was deeply, genuinely funny, and she landed it seven times in a row, each time with the expression of someone accepting an award.

Elizabeth practiced her spinning. She had been working on a one-and-a-half rotation for the past month. She landed it once, then twice, then a third time with enough control that she felt the clean click of a thing mastered, and that felt excellent in a completely different way from the Royal Jellyfish but equally real.

They moved to the foam pits. They moved to the dodgeball court, where Scarlet hit a kid named Marcus three times in a row and then apologized very sincerely and then they all became friends for the duration of the pit session. They moved to the ninja warrior section, where Elizabeth got through seven obstacles and fell on the eighth and felt entirely fine about it.

Then Scarlet grabbed Elizabeth's arm.

"Don't look immediately," she said, in the very specific tone she used when something was happening that required strategy. "Look in about four seconds. At the blue support pillar near the entrance."

Elizabeth counted to four.

She looked.

At the blue support pillar near the entrance, partially obscured by a hanging foam divider, stood a figure wearing a trench coat. The coat was beige. The figure had a mustache — quite a prominent one, really — and was attempting to read a brochure while looking over the top of it at two princesses on a trampoline.

The shoe, where the trench coat ended, was very polished.

"Max," Elizabeth said.

They looked at each other. Then, without a word, they made a plan.

They bounced toward the dodgeball court, which took them near the drinking fountain, which took them past a bench, which took them on a long slow arc toward the far side of the hall. Behind them, at a careful distance, a mustache moved from pillar to pillar.

"He is so bad at this," Scarlet said, in the gentle tone of someone observing a friend attempt a skill they hadn't developed.

"He is excellent at his actual job," Elizabeth said. "Undercover work is different."

"His fake mustache has been on sideways since we started the dodgeball round."

Elizabeth checked without being obvious about it. It was true. The disguise mustache — a slightly larger, curlier affair than his real mustache — had slipped about fifteen degrees to the left and was sitting at an angle that no mustache had ever occupied naturally.

"Don't laugh," Elizabeth said.

"I am not laughing," Scarlet said, with the face of someone who was going to laugh in approximately five seconds.

They walked toward the blue pillar. They walked with the deliberate, unhurried pace of people who had no idea whatsoever that anyone was watching them from behind it.

"Oh," Scarlet said, in a carrying voice. "I wonder where Max could be. Our favorite butler. Not here at Sky Zone, certainly."

"Definitely not hiding behind any of these pillars," Elizabeth agreed.

"Not the blue one or the yellow one or—"

Max stepped out from behind the pillar.

His dignity entered the room about three seconds before the rest of him caught up with it. The trench coat was slightly too short. The rainbow tie — he'd worn his rainbow tie under the trench coat, which told you something important about Max's priorities — was hanging sideways. There were three foam cubes stuck to his hair in locations that suggested he'd spent some time in the foam pit, possibly involuntarily.

"I was ensuring your safety," he said.

"You were spying on us," Scarlet said.

"For safety."

"With a fake mustache over your real mustache?"

Max touched his upper lip. The disguise mustache had now migrated to his chin.

There was a pause while Max looked at the mustache, gathered himself, and reset.

"A disguise," he said, with unshakeable composure, "must have layers."

Elizabeth and Scarlet looked at each other. Then they folded their arms in exactly the way Max folded his arms when he was being disappointed at them — same angle, same tilt, same chin position — and held the posture until his eyes narrowed in recognition.

"Since you caught us during Operation Ice Cream," Elizabeth said, "and since we caught you during Operation Sneaky Butler—"

"I was not operating. I was surveilling."

"—we need a trade," Elizabeth continued.

Max considered this. "A reasonable trade," he said. It was very telling that he specified reasonable immediately. "What are your terms?"

"On the way home," Scarlet said, "you buy us medium sodas."

"And you clean our room this week," Elizabeth added, "since we cleaned yours."

"I also want to put you in charge of the Ladybug Room," Scarlet said.

Max's eye twitched. The Ladybug Room was their old playroom, still filled with glitter, craft supplies, and the remnants of seventeen unfinished projects including a particularly catastrophic bead curtain. "The Ladybug Room," he said carefully.

"And the glitter drawer especially," Scarlet added.

Max looked at the ceiling. Then at the girls. Then at the ceiling again.

"Very well," he said. "Grape for you?" This was to Scarlet.

"Obviously."

"Orange cream for you?" This was to Elizabeth.

"Please."

On the drive home, Max maintained the expression of a man who had lost a small but meaningful battle and was processing this with quiet professionalism. The girls sipped their sodas in the back seat. The evening was warm and the windows were down and the soda was very good.

"Royal Detectives," Max muttered.

Elizabeth looked up from her straw. "What did you say?"

"Nothing," Max said, in the front seat, looking at the road.

Scarlet had heard it. She leaned toward Elizabeth with wide eyes. "Did he just—"

"Say it again," Elizabeth said.

Max didn't say it again.

But the phrase had already landed, soft and certain as a key fitting a lock, and Elizabeth turned it over in her mind all the way home. Royal Detectives. Like it wasn't just a name. Like it was something they already were, and had been, and just didn't have the word for yet.

She wrote it in her notebook when they got home, at the top of a clean page.

Then she added a colon, and waited to see what came after it.

Ms. Ironfist's Test

Ms. Ironfist had been teaching mathematics at the Royal Academy for twenty-three years, and in that time she had developed opinions about effort, precision, and the general potential of young people that she delivered with the subtlety and impact of a thrown encyclopedia.

She was not cruel. Unkind teachers existed, and Ms. Ironfist was not one of them, though she would have been startled to hear it. She believed, with her entire considerable heart, that rigor was a gift — that demanding the best from a student was the highest form of respect you could show them. She believed this so thoroughly that she had never once questioned whether her delivery of it was accessible to everyone, which was the one significant gap in an otherwise excellent philosophy.

Her eyebrows had been permanently set to disappointed for so long that the expression had become her resting face.

Room Four smelled like chalk, sharpened pencils, and the particular kind of silence that means consequences.

Elizabeth had studied. She studied because numbers had a logic to them that she found genuinely satisfying — the way they built on each other, each rule a foundation for the next, nothing arbitrary, everything there for a reason. She liked knowing the reason. She had completed the practice problems twice and then gone back and done the ones at the end of the chapter that Ms. Ironfist had said were optional, because Elizabeth treated optional problems the way some people treated optional vegetables: as something that would matter later.

Scarlet had meant to study.

The week had been busy. There was the vase (broken, partially collected, very much a problem). There was Operation Ice Cream (successful, educational, punished). There was the Sky Zone stakeout (complicated, socially rich, also punished). There was the matter of Max's butler room and thirty-seven rainbow ties in need of organization and one inexplicable pineapple tie that raised more questions than it answered.

Studying had been genuinely on the agenda. It had simply been below several other things.

The test began. Room Four filled with the sound of pencils scratching, which is the only sound that has ever captured exactly what thinking under pressure sounds like. Elizabeth's pencil moved steadily. The problems came to her in sequence, each one unlocking the next the way puzzle pieces fit — she never rushed, but she never stalled, and by the time Ms. Ironfist said "Pencils down" she had checked every answer twice and was quietly satisfied.

Scarlet's pencil had scratched. And stopped. And scratched again. And stopped. The first problem had wanted her to carry a number and the number had resisted being carried. She'd gotten it eventually, maybe, and then the next problem required the number from the first problem and she wasn't actually sure she'd gotten the first one right, and the whole thing had become a tower built on an uncertain

foundation.

When Ms. Ironfist returned the papers, Elizabeth got a 94, which was good enough that Ms. Ironfist marked it with a small nod — the highest compliment available in Room Four.

Scarlet got a 41.

"Miss Scarlet," Ms. Ironfist said, in the flat, final tone she reserved for matters of significant consequence, "please gather your things. You will be attending the remedial section in Room Seven for the remainder of this unit."

Scarlet's face went through three changes very quickly — shock, embarrassment, and then the particular stillness of someone working very hard not to cry in front of twenty-three people.

Room Seven was fine. The teacher there smiled. The problems were easier. The room had a window that looked out over the courtyard garden.

Scarlet hated every second of it. Not because it was bad but because it was somewhere else, and Elizabeth was in Room Four, and math was something she should be able to do if she just tried hard enough, and the fact that she'd landed here felt like proof that she hadn't.

That evening, in their room, she said this into her pillow.

Elizabeth sat down on the floor beside her bed. She waited for Scarlet to run out of the things she needed to say into the pillow. When Scarlet finally went quiet, Elizabeth said: "Then we get you back."

"You can't get me back. It's not a team thing. It's my grade."

"Everything is a team thing," Elizabeth said. "That is specifically my opinion and I am not changing it."

So they made the room a study camp. Elizabeth moved her desk so they could face each other across it. She made flashcards — proper ones, different colors for different concepts, neatly labeled on one side and problem-on the other. Scarlet worked problems on the whiteboard while Max cleaned the room, which he was now obligated to do for two weeks and which meant he heard a great deal of mathematical conversation while pretending to be focused exclusively on dusting.

"Carry the one," Elizabeth said, one Thursday evening.

"I am carrying it," Scarlet said, frowning at the board.

"You dropped it. On the third line."

"It's heavy."

"Numbers are not actually heavy."

"This one is." Scarlet erased the line and started again. Max moved the duster to the window ledge and became very interested in a spot of dust. He was not, Elizabeth suspected, looking at the spot at all.

On the day of the reassessment, Scarlet's hands shook so badly she had to set her pencil down twice before she started writing. Elizabeth was back in Room Four two corridors away, doing her own work, but she'd given Scarlet a small folded note that morning that said only: You know this. Start with what you know.

Scarlet started with what she knew.

The principal appeared in the doorway of Room Seven the next morning before class had properly begun. She was holding a paper. She crossed to Scarlet's desk and set it down.

One hundred percent. Every problem. Clean and correct and showing every step of the working, the way Elizabeth had taught her.

Scarlet ran. She was supposed to walk — the Academy had opinions about this — but she ran down the corridor and pushed open the door to Room Four and Elizabeth stood up from her desk without even knowing she was going to, and they hugged each other in the middle of the classroom with the door open and twenty-three students watching, which was embarrassing and completely worth it.

Ms. Ironfist looked up from her ledger.

"Acceptable improvement," she said.

It was the quietest, driest, most minimal possible praise.

It was also, from Ms. Ironfist, roughly equivalent to a standing ovation.

The Sunflower Substitute

Ms. Ironfist was absent on a Tuesday.

This was information that reached Room Four like a weather report of unexpected sunshine — greeted with the same involuntary, slightly guilty delight of a school day where the hardest thing is figuring out what to do with all the lightness.

The substitute arrived approximately forty-five seconds after the bell, which was fast enough to establish presence but not so fast as to seem anxious about it. Her name was Mrs. Rosie. She wore a dress printed with sunflowers that were large enough and yellow enough that they seemed to generate their own small atmospheric system — you looked at her and felt, briefly, that it might be warmer than it was. Her hair was brown, her eyes were blue, and she was carrying a basket over one arm from which she immediately began distributing clementines to the front row.

"Good morning," she said, with the warmth of someone who genuinely meant it. "I'm Mrs. Rosie. Ms. Ironfist is at home resting — apparently even geometry teachers need to take a day off sometimes." She smiled when she said this, which made it funny rather than disrespectful. "We're going to have math today, but we're going to do it outside."

A silence.

Scarlet turned to Elizabeth.

Elizabeth turned to Scarlet.

Math. Outside. The concept seemed illegal. Math was a thing that happened in rooms with specific smells and specific acoustics and a specific ratio of chalk dust to dread. It was not a thing that happened outside. Outside was where math was not.

"Is she allowed to do that?" Scarlet whispered.

"I don't know the rule that would prevent it," Elizabeth said, which was as close as she could get to certainty.

The garden outside Room Four was a long rectangle of grass bordered by flower beds and one spectacular old oak tree at the far end. Mrs. Rosie led them to the sunflower bed along the south wall — sixteen sunflowers, ranging from waist height to head height, their faces turned toward the midday light with the patient, golden optimism that sunflowers specialized in.

The lesson was about estimating height by measuring shadows and angles. It required knowing the time of day, the position of the sun, and some geometry that turned out to be somewhat elegant when you were looking at an actual flower rather than a diagram in a book. Elizabeth found the angles immediately satisfying. She got the first calculation right and it gave her a small, clean buzz of satisfaction.

Scarlet made a mistake on the second problem and braced for the sound of a ruler.

It didn't come.

Mrs. Rosie knelt beside her — actually knelt, on the grass, without concern for her sunflower dress — and looked at her calculation. "You measured from the wrong base point," she said pleasantly. "See here — try again from this line."

Scarlet tried again.

"Much better." Mrs. Rosie stood, brushing grass from her knee. "Mistakes are just clues wearing disguises."

Scarlet stared at her. "What does that mean?"

"It means when you get an answer wrong, the wrong answer tells you exactly what you need to learn. It's not a failure. It's information." She moved on to the next student, leaving Scarlet standing in the sunflower bed with an expression Elizabeth had never quite seen on her face before — the look of someone who had just been handed a useful tool they hadn't known they needed.

At lunch, under the old oak tree, Elizabeth noticed something.

Mrs. Rosie's canvas bag was open beside her on the bench, and from inside it, a photograph had slipped partway out. The photograph showed two women in academic robes, arms around each other, grinning at the camera in the specific way people grin at cameras when they've just survived something significant together — a graduation, maybe, or a challenge. One of them was unmistakably Mrs. Rosie, younger, the same warm open face. The other woman had severe dark hair and eyebrows that were currently, in this photo, tilted upward in the closest thing to a smile they had apparently ever attempted.

"You know Ms. Ironfist?" Scarlet said, before social judgment had a chance to intervene.

Mrs. Rosie looked at the photo, then smiled and tucked it back. "We were roommates in college. Thirty years ago."

"But she's..." Scarlet looked for the right word.

"Terrifying," Elizabeth supplied.

Mrs. Rosie looked at them both for a moment with an expression that was weighing something. "She cares enormously about teaching," she said finally. "I know that's hard to see when she's holding a ruler. But she stays up late grading. She writes detailed notes on every wrong answer — not to correct, but to explain. She wants you to understand. That's not nothing."

"Does she tell jokes?" Scarlet asked. The information from the previous conversation was apparently not yet gone.

Mrs. Rosie's eyes crinkled. "When she's not holding a ruler."

For the rest of the week, Room Four breathed differently. Not just students — the actual room seemed to. The same problems, the same curriculum, but approached as something that could be interesting rather than something that had to be endured. Questions got asked. Mistakes got made and then understood. The oak tree saw more mathematics than it had probably expected when it first put down roots.

On Friday morning, Mrs. Rosie made an announcement.

"I want to tell you something," she said, from the front of the room, in the tone of someone who has thought carefully about what they're about to say. "Every classroom keeps secrets. Information that gets shared that maybe wasn't meant for everyone. History that is stored in the walls." She paused. "The best students I know are the ones who pay attention not just to the lesson on the board but to the things between the lines."

Elizabeth sat up straighter.

Scarlet felt the word secrets land somewhere specific in her chest, like a stone dropped into still water.

Mrs. Rosie's eyes moved across the class — and for just one second, unmistakably, they rested on the two princesses.

It was a very small moment. It could have been anything.

But Elizabeth wrote it down in her notebook anyway, because Elizabeth wrote down the things that felt like they might matter later.

Mrs. Rosie, she wrote. Knows something. Or wants us to think she does. Or both.

And below that, underlined:

Pay attention to the things between the lines.

The Ladybug Room

The new room happened on a Thursday, which was not a special day in any official sense, which made it more of a surprise.

Mom appeared after breakfast with the expression she used when she had been keeping something to herself for longer than was comfortable and had finally decided to stop. "Come with me," she said. "Both of you. Bring nothing."

She led them through the east wing, past the library, past the formal reception rooms with their careful furniture arrangements, past the corridor with the portraits of ancestors that had always seemed vaguely supervisory. The castle had parts that the girls knew intimately — every loose stone, every door that stuck, every window with the view that made you feel like the world was a painting — and parts they'd never explored, and Mom was taking them steadily deeper into one of the latter.

At the end of a shorter corridor that turned right instead of going straight, there was a door.

It was carved mahogany, dark and warm, with a handle shaped like a climbing vine. Mom produced a key from her pocket — the old kind, ornate brass — and fit it into the lock.

"We had it redone," she said. "Over the summer. It's yours."

She pushed the door open.

Elizabeth and Scarlet stood in the doorway and forgot, completely, how to use language.

The room was round, built into one of the castle's turret sections, with walls that had been painted to look like a meadow seen from the inside — green grass curling around the baseboards, wildflowers climbing toward the ceiling, the ceiling itself a pale blue sky with small painted clouds and, among the clouds, dozens of tiny painted ladybugs in brilliant red and black. They glowed very faintly, as if lit from behind, and in the daylight they were warm and cheerful and in the dark, Elizabeth would discover later, they lit up like tiny nightlights.

There was a bunk bed. There was a desk for each of them. There were bookshelves built into the curved walls that looked as though they had grown there. There was a window seat with cushions the color of clover.

There was a water slide.

It wasn't large by slide standards — it started at the second level of the bunk bed and curved down and away through an opening in the floor the size of a medium door. But it was, undeniably, a water slide.

"It goes to the pool," Dad said, appearing behind them in the doorway in the manner of someone who had been waiting to say this specific sentence for a significant amount of time.

Scarlet made a sound that was technically not a whoop. It had the architecture of a whoop, and the intent of a whoop, and the emotional weight of at least three whoops.

"Press the button," Dad said.

"What button?" Elizabeth asked.

She noticed the edge of the rug lifting slightly. Under it, in the floor, was a button. Gold-plated. Star-shaped. If a button could look excited, this one was pulling it off.

Scarlet pressed it before Elizabeth had finished her sentence.

WHOOSH.

The water came from somewhere inside the wall, a sudden cold rush that sent Scarlet's laugh bouncing off every painted ladybug in the ceiling. It lasted for about eight seconds and then cut off cleanly, leaving the slide gleaming and ready.

"Dad," Elizabeth said.

"Yes?"

She looked at the meadow walls. At the sky ceiling. At the bunk bed and the bookshelves and the window seat and the water slide. "This is the best room in the castle."

"By a significant margin," Scarlet added, with the authority of someone who has toured the whole building.

Their parents left eventually, after a meal together in the new room that felt like the beginning of something. Night came in through the window and the painted stars on the ceiling — she hadn't even noticed the stars yet, tiny and careful and silver between the ladybugs — lit up one by one, and the ladybugs glowed their gentle red, and the bunk bed was excellent, and the whole room felt like being inside something that had been made with specific love for the specific people who were now inside it.

"Best room ever," Scarlet whispered from the top bunk, in the particular soft voice she used for things she meant completely.

"Best room ever," Elizabeth agreed, from the bottom.

Then the walkie-talkie crackled.

It was sitting on Elizabeth's desk. She had put it there when they moved in, along with the rest of her things — old, battery-operated, blue-green plastic, a set she'd owned since she was seven. She had not turned it on. Neither had Scarlet. They hadn't even discussed it.

Static. The specific hiss of a channel looking for a signal.

Then a voice. Low, careful, the words spaced out as if they were being chosen in real time.

"The map is behind the bunk. Find the star."

Then silence.

Scarlet's head appeared over the railing of the top bunk, her hair falling around her face, her eyes enormous. "Did your walkie-talkie just talk by itself?"

"Yes," Elizabeth said.

"Do walkie-talkies do that?"

"No," Elizabeth said. "They do not."

"Find the star," Scarlet repeated, and something about saying the words out loud made them feel more real and also more urgent and also slightly hair-raising in the best possible way. "There are stars everywhere in this room."

"Painted ones," Elizabeth said. "But also—"

She got out of bed. Moved to the back of the room, behind the bunk bed, and looked at the wall. The painted grass curved up from the baseboard. The painted flowers nodded in a wind that didn't exist. And there, at roughly knee height, where the wall met the corner, was something that wasn't painted.

A star. Carved into the stone. Small, precise, the lines cut clean.

"Scarlet," Elizabeth said.

Scarlet was already sliding down from the top bunk with the speed of someone who had anticipated this moment. She knelt beside Elizabeth and touched the carved star with the tip of one finger.

Something clicked. Deep in the wall, mechanical and definite. A hairline seam appeared, straight and vertical, six inches to the right of the star.

Elizabeth looked at her sister. "I think," she said carefully, "our room has a secret."

Scarlet put her hand against the wall and pushed.

The seam opened slightly — enough to feel the cool air on the other side, the particular coolness of somewhere that had been closed for a long time — and then held.

Not yet. Not enough information. Not tonight.

But the wall had an answer, and they had found the question, and tomorrow they were going to need a better plan than pajamas and enthusiasm.

Elizabeth went back to her bed. Got out her notebook. Wrote at the top of a fresh page:

Things behind the wall.

And waited to see what she could fill in.

The Field Trip Note

The Whispering Woods got its name honestly.

It didn't whisper the way people whispered — not words or warnings or the kind of thing you'd write down if you could. It whispered the way old places whispered, the way forests did when you went deep enough into them: leaves rubbing together in a language made of texture rather than sound, water moving under stones without quite showing itself, birds calling from branches in patterns that seemed purposeful and almost weren't.

Mrs. Rosie led the class along a path that ran through the middle of it on a Wednesday morning, carrying a clipboard and stopping every few minutes to point out something worth knowing — a mushroom ring, a patch of silver ferns that only grew in this specific kind of light, a type of moss that could tell you north from south if you knew which part of it grew fastest. Everyone carried notebooks. Most of them were writing facts about moss.

Scarlet's notebook had a page of moss facts and then a drawing of the path they'd taken, marked with a small X at every interesting-looking detour.

Elizabeth carried the compass.

They'd taken it from the space behind the wall — the passage they'd found behind the carved star in the Ladybug Room was narrow and lit only by a faint phosphorescence in the stone, barely wide enough for a sideways crawl, and at the end of it, on a small stone ledge, they'd found two things: a compass and a folded map that was so old the paper had gone almost transparent at the folds. The map they'd left where it was, photographed carefully. The compass they'd brought.

It was blue — not painted blue but blue in the glass of the needle housing, a blue that matched the broken vase in a way that probably wasn't coincidence and sat in Elizabeth's pocket now, doing what compasses were supposed to do, except the needle seemed to have opinions that weren't strictly north.

About forty minutes into the trail, it moved.

Not the drift of an ordinary compass — not the small correction as you turned — but a decisive rotation, fast and purposeful, pointing off the path toward the left, toward a section of the wood where the trees grew closer together and the light came through them in long diagonal bars that looked like the inside of a cathedral.

Elizabeth stopped walking. Checked it again. The needle held.

Ahead of them, Mrs. Rosie was explaining the difference between safe mushrooms and mushrooms that, according to local legend, screamed when stepped on. The class was appropriately invested in this.

Elizabeth touched Scarlet's sleeve. Showed her the compass.

Scarlet looked at the needle. Looked at the woods to the left. Looked at Elizabeth.

There was no conversation needed. There never was.

They slipped sideways off the path — not running, not obviously departing, just gradually being in a different location than they had been — and followed the needle through the trees. The light changed as they moved deeper, became that specific amber of midafternoon through leaves, and the sound of the class faded behind them until it was just the woods again.

The compass led them to a tree.

It was enormous — older than anything else in the forest, trunk wider than Elizabeth's arm span, bark so deeply grooved it looked like a map of itself. At the base, between two major roots that curved up and outward like embracing arms, the trunk had hollowed over the years into a space just large enough to fit your arm into up to the elbow. The hollow was dark. The hollow smelled of old wood and stone and something faintly like the sea.

Elizabeth reached in.

Her fingers found the edge of something smooth and cool. She pulled it out carefully.

A silver envelope. The outside was dusty in the way things get dusty when they've been somewhere for a long time, the gray-white dust of stillness. But the seal on the back — a circle pressed into purple wax — was fresh. The wax was still slightly yielding, still catching small fingerprint ridges, which meant it had been placed there recently.

Very recently.

Elizabeth held it in both hands and looked at it. Scarlet stood beside her and looked at it. From somewhere behind them, Mrs. Rosie's voice carried faintly, now on the subject of how trees communicated through their root systems, which felt accidentally relevant.

"Open it," Scarlet said, so quietly it was barely sound at all.

Elizabeth broke the seal.

Inside was a single piece of paper, thick and cream-colored, and on it, in handwriting that moved with the precision of someone who took penmanship seriously, was one sentence. The ink was purple, bright and glossy, catching the light with a slight iridescence.

I see you have found the compass. Meet me at the Crystal Cave.

That was all.

No signature. No location details. Just the sentence, and the ink, and the fact that someone knew they had found the compass at all.

A chill moved through Scarlet that had nothing to do with the temperature. Elizabeth felt it too, the specific quality of being known about without knowing who knows you. It felt like a hand on the back of your neck from the direction you weren't facing.

"Someone knows," Scarlet breathed.

"About the compass?"

"About us." Scarlet turned slowly, scanning the trees. They were ordinary trees. Bark and roots and dappled light and nothing watching. Nothing that she could see. "They put this here after we found the

compass. Which means they were watching."

Elizabeth folded the note and tucked it into the inside pocket of her notebook. She didn't say anything yet. She was thinking, and Elizabeth thinking was a process that looked like stillness but felt, from the inside, like a lot of activity.

A branch snapped.

They both spun.

Mrs. Rosie stood on the path ten feet behind them, clipboard in hand, expression entirely pleasant. She had appeared without sound, which was either very good hiking practice or something else.

"The Messenger Tree is very old," she said. "People used to leave notes here for each other, before there were other ways to communicate." She said it as if she were simply continuing a thought she'd started earlier. "Messages for travelers. Coordinates for meeting places."

Elizabeth said, before she could stop herself: "This note isn't old."

Mrs. Rosie looked at her. The pleasant expression didn't change. "Then it must be very important," she said, and turned back to the path with the smooth finality of someone who has said exactly what they meant and not a word more.

Scarlet stared after her.

"Does she know?" she asked, when Mrs. Rosie was far enough ahead.

"I don't know," Elizabeth said.

"Do we trust her?"

Elizabeth watched Mrs. Rosie rejoin the group ahead, pointing something out in the canopy, the class looking up. She tucked the notebook under her arm. The word meet sat in the note like a small lit fuse.

"Not yet," she said.

The wind moved through the Whispering Woods, and for one clear, unmistakable second, the leaves made a sound that was very close to specific words.

Crystal Cave. Crystal Cave. Crystal Cave.

Or possibly it was just the wind. This was the thing about the Whispering Woods. You could never be entirely certain.

Picnic at the Crystal Cave

Mom announced the picnic at breakfast on a Saturday with the particular energy of someone who had been thinking about strawberry tarts for at least forty-eight hours and had finally found the framing to make them happen.

"The weather is perfect," she said, spreading her hands to indicate the sunlight coming through the kitchen window as evidence, which it was. "We'll go to the woods. Your father has claims about the ideal spot."

Dad looked up from his coffee. "I don't just have claims. I have experience."

"Tell us about the experience," Mom said.

"The best location for a picnic is wherever you bring the picnic," Dad said, with the confidence of a man who had rehearsed this. "And this year I am bringing strawberry tarts."

"He gets them from the bakery at the edge of town," Mom told the girls, as if this were a secret Dad wasn't sitting three feet away for. "They're very good."

"We'll take the east path," Dad said. "The meadow clearing. Twenty minutes in."

Scarlet had gone very still in the way she went still when her mind was moving faster than her face was. Elizabeth, beside her, was doing the same thing but showing it differently — her hand wrapped around her orange juice glass, not drinking, doing the arithmetic.

They were going to the Whispering Woods. The picnic was going to the Whispering Woods, where the note had said Crystal Cave, where the note had been left by someone who knew about the compass, and now the entire family was going to the Whispering Woods on an apparently unrelated but suspiciously well-timed family outing.

Elizabeth touched the compass through her pocket. It was warm.

"Wonderful," Elizabeth said, and meant it for at least two reasons.

* * *

The picnic materialized in the meadow clearing with the efficiency of a household that had done this before — Max producing a blanket from what appeared to be a very organized bag, with corners that went down like they had ambitions about staying, the guards setting up the folding table, Mom and Dad arranging sandwiches with the low-grade constructive argument that meant they were both happy.

The strawberry tarts, Elizabeth observed, were extraordinary. This was not the point. She was working on a different point.

She touched the compass again. It was pulsing slightly toward the trees.

"We're going to pick flowers," Scarlet announced, with the casual authority of someone who had prepared this sentence. She was already half-standing. "For the blanket. To put flowers on the blanket."

Max, who was smoothing a corner, did not look up. But his pause was precisely one second longer than it needed to be to smooth a corner. "Flowers," he said.

"Yes," Elizabeth said. "Outdoor ones. From outdoors."

"How specific," Max said, and somehow the words meant something.

They walked away across the meadow before the sentence could develop further.

The trees closed around them the moment they stepped off the path. The compass needle swung forward immediately, pulling toward something with a certainty that felt different from navigation — purposeful, almost urgent. They followed it without speaking, moving through the dappled light of the late morning, and the forest sounds adjusted around them the way forest sounds do when you stop being visitors and start being something that belongs in it.

Ten minutes in, the compass led them to a cliffside.

It rose from the forest floor without warning, grey stone draped with a curtain of vines and flowering ivy that made it look like a green wall. The vines hung so thick you couldn't see anything behind them until you were close enough to put your hands on them, and when Elizabeth did, she felt the cold mineral air moving from behind them and knew.

They pulled the vines aside.

The cave opened into the cliff like a held breath that finally released. The entrance was low enough that they had to duck, and then suddenly the space expanded, and they stood upright in a chamber that was roughly circular and maybe twenty feet across and higher than the entrance had implied, rising to a pointed natural vault overhead.

Purple crystals grew from the walls.

Not a few — not the scattered geode inclusions you sometimes found in rock — but walls of them, thick and clustered, from floor to ceiling, filling the space with a pale violet light that seemed to come from inside the stone itself rather than from any particular source. The crystals were the exact color of the ink on the note. Elizabeth looked at them and felt the hair on her arms rise in the most interesting possible way.

The cave smelled of stone and cool water and something very faintly sweet, like rain that had fallen somewhere else and traveled here.

In the center, a flat natural table of rock jutted from the wall. On it sat two cans of cold grape soda and one of orange cream.

Scarlet stared at them. "Someone left us soda."

"Someone knew our flavors," Elizabeth said.

"That's either very thoughtful or deeply alarming."

"Why not both," Elizabeth said, which was not a question.

There was a wooden box beside the sodas. Small, dark, the wood worn smooth in the way of old objects that had been handled regularly. Sealed with a small brass catch.

Before they could reach for it, the cave made a sound.

Scritch. Scratch.

From behind one of the larger crystal clusters — a cluster near the right wall that jutted out like a small promontory — something moved. Something mechanical. They heard it before they saw it: the careful, slightly uneven movement of jointed metal on stone.

It emerged from behind the crystals and stopped in a pool of purple light and looked at them.

It was an owl.

Mechanical, precisely constructed, brass feathers individually articulated over a copper body, glass eyes that caught the crystal light and held it like small lamps. Its feet clicked delicately on the stone. It was maybe a foot tall. It turned its head — the articulation was extraordinary, smooth and silent — and looked at them with the unhurried regard of something that had been waiting for a specific event and had just watched it arrive.

Then it hooted once — a soft, rounded sound, more musical than a real owl, as if the mechanism had been tuned — and tapped the wooden box with one brass talon.

"Is it telling us to open the box?" Elizabeth asked.

"Either that," Scarlet said, "or it wants a sandwich."

Elizabeth opened the box.

Inside, nested in purple velvet, lay a shard of glass.

Blue glass. Ice-blue, curving slightly, one surface smooth and one fracture-edged, and the size and curve of it matched exactly — exactly, without question — the curve of a piece she'd been looking at for weeks in a silk scarf on their bedroom floor.

It was part of the vase.

A piece of the vase. Here. In a cave. In a box. Delivered by a brass owl.

Scarlet's face had gone pale. Not the pale of fear exactly but the pale of standing at the edge of something much bigger than you'd expected and looking down.

"How did a piece of the vase get here," Scarlet said. It wasn't a question. It was more like saying a thing out loud to make sure you'd heard it correctly.

The owl blinked its glass eyes, one after the other, in a slow mechanical sequence. From outside the cave, carried through the vine curtain:

"Girls!" Mom's voice, warm and distant. "Lunch!"

Elizabeth took the shard. Scarlet took the soda cans, because she was Scarlet and there was no universe in which she was leaving the grape soda. They stepped back through the vines into the daylight, which was bright enough after the cave that they both blinked for a moment.

Elizabeth held the glass piece in her fist, tight, all the way back to the picnic blanket.

She thought about the note that knew about the compass. She thought about the soda in their specific flavors. She thought about the owl, waiting.

And she thought about the fact that they had broken the vase, and hidden it, and told no one except Max.

And someone had found a piece of it before they had.

The strawberry tarts, when she finally sat down and ate one, were just as good as advertised.

She barely tasted them.

The Clue in the Glass

Back at the picnic blanket, with the afternoon sun warm on their backs and the forest breathing quietly behind them, Elizabeth sat with the glass shard hidden under her napkin and tried to eat a cucumber sandwich as if nothing particular had occurred.

She was not very convincing. Her jaw worked, and the sandwich disappeared, and she looked like someone doing a performance of eating a sandwich rather than simply doing it.

Scarlet, beside her, had eaten half her own sandwich and was now staring at a point approximately three feet in front of her on the blanket, which was also not very convincing. She snapped back into focus when Dad made a joke, laughed a second after everyone else, and then looked at Elizabeth with the expression that meant *can we go yet*.

Not yet. They had to wait.

"Look," Scarlet whispered, twenty minutes later, when their parents had drifted into conversation with each other and Max had taken the guard rotation up the east trail. "Look at the glass."

Elizabeth shifted the shard under the napkin, turning it slightly toward the sunlight.

Something happened.

In the direct sunlight, when the angle was exactly right — the angle was very specific, you had to tilt the piece about thirty degrees and let the light hit the convex surface — something appeared inside the glass itself. Not paint. Not etching. Something that had been part of the material from the beginning, invisible in normal light, only readable when the sun was behind it at a particular hour.

Tiny letters, frosted into the glass, fine as the lines of a fingerprint.

Three words and an image. THE ROYAL CLOCKTOWER. And below the words, small and precise, drawn in the same frosted technique: a gear and a wrench.

"It's not just a shard," Elizabeth said. Her voice was very level. "It's a clue."

Scarlet leaned in, squinting. "Someone put writing in the glass."

"Someone put it there a long time ago, probably. When the vase was made." Elizabeth turned the shard slowly, watching the letters appear and disappear as the angle changed. They were only visible in that specific sunlight, at that specific angle. You'd never see them looking at the vase normally. You'd have to break it first.

She thought about that. She thought about it carefully.

"The vase was designed to be broken," she said.

Scarlet's head turned toward her slowly. "What?"

"Not destroyed. Not lost. Broken into pieces so the pieces could be found. Each piece has a clue in it. That's why the note said it was the first clue. Not the first problem — the first clue." Elizabeth's hand

closed around the shard and then opened again. "Someone built this. The whole thing. As a kind of... test."

"A clue left by someone who knows we broke the vase," Scarlet said.

"And who knows about the cave."

"And who knows our soda flavors," Scarlet said. "Don't forget the soda. That's the part that feels most pointed somehow."

They looked at each other. The name they were both thinking sat between them like a card face-down on a table, and neither of them turned it over yet because once you turned it over you couldn't un-see what it said.

The Clocktower.

* * *

The Royal Clocktower rose at the northeast corner of the castle, taller than everything around it, a square column of grey stone that held the works of the great clock at the top and had kept the time for the kingdom for two centuries without ever being significantly wrong. At night it glowed — four great clock faces, one on each cardinal side, lit from behind — and the sound of its gears could be heard from the eastern corridors if you stood still and listened.

No one went up there except the clockwork maintenance crew, who came once every three years, and possibly also Max.

It was past midnight when they went.

The castle was in its deep sleep, the kind that only happens after a day that had its picnic and its conversation and its proper tiredness, and Elizabeth had been awake for the full hour between midnight and one o'clock out of pure preparedness. Scarlet had been awake the entire time out of pure excitement. They moved quietly through corridors they now knew cold — every creak, every turn, every guard timing — and the Clocktower door was old enough to be unlocked by the kind of key that lived on the maintenance ring in the east utility room, which Elizabeth had borrowed and replaced so many times that it barely registered as a thing she was doing anymore.

The stairs spiraled upward in the dark. Elizabeth's hand on the cold stone wall. Scarlet's breathing above her, slower and more measured than her usual breathing, which meant she was doing the thing she did when she was actually nervous — slowing herself down deliberately, the way Max had taught them without meaning to.

The top of the tower was a revelation.

The clock room filled the entire top floor, open on all four sides to the night air through stone arches, and the machinery of it was enormous and beautiful — great bronze gears taller than either of them, turning with a slow majesty that you felt in your chest as well as heard. Bells hung above in graduated sizes, the smallest the size of a fist, the largest the size of a wardrobe, all suspended from iron framework and waiting for the hour. The room smelled of oil and old metal and the specific cold that comes with height.

The gears ticked.

A figure stood beside the largest clock face, looking out through the arch at the nighttime kingdom below.

Scarlet grabbed Elizabeth's hand. Hard.

The figure turned at the sound of their step.

It lowered its hood.

Max the Butler stood in the Clocktower at one in the morning, not in his white suit but in a canvas apron covered with pockets — small pockets, large pockets, pockets within pockets — full of the tools and instruments of someone who built things rather than just maintained them. Inventor's goggles were pushed up on his forehead. A brass remote control sat in his gloved hand. He looked at them with the unhurried expression of someone who has been waiting for a specific arrival.

"You are late," he said. "By approximately eleven minutes. The note said meet, which implies a reasonable promptness."

Elizabeth's mouth was working. "You made the owl," she said.

"Yes."

"You left the notes."

"Also yes."

"You knew about the vase." This was Scarlet, who had moved to the center of the room and was looking at him directly, and her voice had in it something that wasn't quite anger and wasn't quite hurt but was made of both things in equal measure. "You knew the whole time."

Max's expression changed in a way that was very small and very specific. The exact way someone looks when they are being entirely honest for the first time about something they have been careful with. "I knew," he said. "I have always known."

"Then why didn't you just tell us?" Scarlet asked. "We were terrified. We thought we were in the worst trouble of our lives."

"You were." Max turned the remote control over in his hands. "But being in trouble is not the same as being in danger. And what I needed to know — what the castle needed to know — was what you would do while you were in it. Would you hide? Would you confess? Would you run from it or toward it?" He looked at them both, at the end of this, with an expression that was difficult to name precisely. It might have been pride. "You did all three things, at different moments, in roughly the right order."

Elizabeth held up the glass shard. In the clock room light, the frosted letters glowed faintly. "Can the vase be fixed?"

Max reached into one of his apron's many pockets and produced a small bottle. The liquid inside was not quite golden and not quite amber — it moved when the bottle moved, as if it had somewhere to go. In the light from the clock face it glowed.

"With this," he said. "But fixing the vase is only the material part of the task." He held it out. Elizabeth took it. "The other half is telling the truth."

Above them, the great bells shifted in their frames as the minute hand found the next position. The room hummed with the vibration of something that had been keeping perfect time for longer than anyone in it had been alive.

"To your father," Max said quietly. "To your mother. All of it. The skating and the crash and the hiding and the ice cream and the coin jar and everything that came after." He looked at them steadily. "Not because they won't be upset. But because they deserve to know, and because you deserve to stop carrying it."

The bells above them had not struck yet. They were waiting, the way everything in that room seemed to wait — with precision, with purpose, with the absolute certainty that the right moment would come and when it did, nothing in the world would be able to stop them.

Golden Glue

The golden glue, when Elizabeth uncorked the small bottle the next morning, smelled like something between honey and sunlight and the good part of an afternoon that was going well.

"It smells like second chances," Elizabeth said.

"It smells like toast," Scarlet said. "Very warm, very expensive toast."

Both of them were right, in the way that things can be right in two completely different directions at once.

They spread black velvet on the floor of the Ladybug Room — the kind of velvet Max used for laying out fine jewelry when it needed cleaning — and unwrapped the silk scarf with the careful reverence of something that had been sacred-by-necessity for several weeks. The shards slid onto the velvet with their familiar soft clink, ice-blue and gold-painted and still, when the morning light caught them, startlingly beautiful.

Elizabeth picked up the camera first.

"We need a before picture," she said.

Scarlet looked at her. "Why would we want proof of how bad it is?"

"Because." Elizabeth arranged the pieces, gently, just enough to show what they were and what they weren't yet. "Mom should see that we didn't pretend it never happened. That we looked at it. That we took a picture so she'd know we looked at it."

Flash. The blue glass shards sparkled in the camera's light like something that hadn't decided yet whether it was beautiful or broken. It was both, Elizabeth thought. That was exactly what it was.

Then they began.

It took the whole morning.

The golden glue worked with a logic that felt more like intention than chemistry — a single drop from the bottle on one edge, held to its matching piece, and then a warmth, a pull, as if the glass remembered what it had been and was choosing it again. The connection happened at the fracture line exactly. No excess. No misalignment.

"It wants to be whole," Scarlet said, after the third successful join.

"Don't get philosophical about glue," Elizabeth said.

"I'm not getting philosophical. I'm making an observation."

"That is philosophical."

"Then I'm philosophically observing."

They fell into a rhythm: Elizabeth applying the glue in careful drops, Scarlet holding pieces steady with tweezers borrowed from Max's kit, both of them breathing slowly in the way they did when

something required sustained attention. Max knocked once at ten o'clock and entered with sandwiches and two glasses of water and the expression of someone who has seen enough important work to know when not to interrupt it. He left the sandwiches on the windowsill and departed without comment.

"How's the repair?" he asked, from the doorway, briefly.

"Slow," Elizabeth said.

"Sticky," Scarlet said.

"Good," Max said. "Most important repairs are."

The gold lines emerged where the cracks had been.

They were beautiful. That was the thing that neither of them had expected — not the beauty of something restored to what it was before but the beauty of something becoming what it could be now. The gold ran through the blue glass like river tributaries on a map, like lightning caught and held in place, like secret paths only visible from the right angle. The painted roses on the outside caught the gold lines and looked brighter for them. The broken places had become design.

Scarlet touched the finished vase — touching the table beside it, not the vase itself, as if it were still too new to be certain of — and said, very quietly: "It's prettier now."

There was no hole, no obvious missing place, nothing a person could point to and call incomplete. But near the base, where the gold lines met and parted, Elizabeth noticed a tiny branching shape that looked less like a crack and more like a route.

"That's the point," Elizabeth said. "I think that was always the point."

They found Mom and Dad in the Royal Library, which was a large, warm room on the west side of the castle that always smelled of old paper and the particular softness of well-handled books. Mom was reading. Dad was supposed to be reading but had fallen asleep over his book, which he was holding upside down in a way that suggested he'd been unconscious for a while. He woke up when they came in, looked at them, and became instantly, inexplicably aware that something important was happening.

Elizabeth set the vase on the reading table, between the lamp and a pile of Dad's notes. In the library light, the gold veins gleamed.

Dad went very still.

"That's—"

"Dad," Elizabeth said.

And then they told everything. The race. The skates. The marble floor and the corner and the crash. The scarf and the hiding. Max's deal and the Speech and the coin jar and the midnight sundaes. The punishment. The Clocktower and the brass owl and the Crystal Cave and the note that knew their soda flavors. The secret glue and the hidden clues and all of it, in order, in the light of the library lamps, while Mom and Dad listened and said nothing until they were done.

When they finished, the room was quiet for a long moment.

Scarlet's eyes had filled with tears somewhere in the middle of the telling and she'd let them, because they were real and this was the moment for real things.

Mom didn't say anything. She stood up from her chair and opened her arms.

Both girls crossed the library floor faster than they'd moved in weeks and went into the hug, which was the kind that pressed the tears out properly and held long enough for the shaking to stop.

"I forgive you," Mom said, over their heads. "I'm just very, very glad you told the truth."

Dad, when the hug finally released them, was looking at the vase with an expression Elizabeth couldn't quite read. He reached out and touched one of the gold veins along the side, following it with one finger to where it split and ran in two directions.

"Why," he said, "does my vase look more magical than it did before?"

Elizabeth laughed. It came out wet and surprised and completely genuine. "Long story," she said.

"We have time," Mom said.

"A lot of time," Dad agreed. "Starting with: what is a brass owl, and where is it now, and when can I meet it?"

Royal Detectives

The sign appeared on the door of the Ladybug Room the morning after the confession.

It was hand-lettered, which meant Max had lettered it, in the precise unhurried style that Max applied to everything from breakfast tray arrangements to disciplinary conversations. The wood was dark and looked expensive. The letters were gold.

ROYAL DETECTIVE HEADQUARTERS

And below that, in smaller letters that had clearly been added as an afterthought that Max had felt strongly about:

NO BUTLERS WITHOUT KNOCKING.

"You wrote that yourself," Scarlet said, reading the smaller text with her arms crossed.

"A wise butler anticipates future policy before it becomes official," Max said, from the corridor behind her, where he was pretending to be en route to somewhere else.

"You specifically put that rule there so you'd already be following it before we made it."

"That is correct. It demonstrates initiative."

Elizabeth was already inside the room, arranging the investigative resources on her desk with the focused energy of someone who had been waiting for permission to do this and had finally received it. The objects were: two walkie-talkies, both functional; the blue compass, which was still warm in a way it shouldn't have been; the camera, which had proven its usefulness; the small hand mirror from Operation Ice Cream, which had also proven its usefulness; and a new notebook labeled, in Elizabeth's handwriting, IMPORTANT CLUES AND ALSO SNACKS.

She had added the snacks appendix for Scarlet. It was a good faith effort.

"We need a system," Elizabeth said, when Scarlet came in and shut the door.

"We need cases," Scarlet said, sitting on the bed. "A system is the thing you put around cases. Cases come first."

"The vase case isn't finished. We know Max built the owl, but we don't know who built the vase. We don't know who sent the first note, or how someone knew we had the compass."

"Max sent the note."

"Max said he tested whether we were ready to protect the castle's secrets. He didn't say he was the one who left the compass for us." Elizabeth opened the notebook. "The compass was already in the passage behind the wall when we found it. Max didn't put it there — the passage was sealed."

Scarlet sat up a little straighter. "So Max isn't the beginning of it."

"Max is a part of it. But not the beginning." Elizabeth tapped the pen against the page. "The vase is older than Max. The clues in the glass, the system of hidden locations, the Crystal Cave — that's all older."

Max is the keeper of something that someone else built."

She wrote MRS. ROSIE beneath that and circled it twice. "And she saw the Messenger Tree note before we did. Or she knew to stand where she could see us find it. Either way, she belongs on the board."

"We do not have a board," Scarlet said.

"We have a wall. A board is just a wall with confidence."

"Then who built it?"

"That," Elizabeth said, "is the case that comes after the current case."

She opened to a new page. Wrote at the top: CASE #2. Then waited.

That night, the compass glowed.

It sat on Elizabeth's desk and pulsed with the kind of light that was very clearly not sunlight and not moonlight and not the glow of the neon stars on the ceiling. A low, rhythmic blue, slightly brighter than the glass itself could account for: thump, pause, thump, pause, in a pattern that after a minute felt less like a light and more like something beating.

They both sat up in their bunks.

"That's new," Scarlet said.

Elizabeth was already out of bed. The compass needle, when she picked it up, had rotated exactly thirty degrees from its previous position and was pointing northwest. The glass face was warm against her palm.

"It's pointing at the woods," Elizabeth said.

"The Crystal Cave?"

"Further than the cave." She stood at the window. The Whispering Woods was a dark band beyond the castle grounds, and beyond it, following the needle's direction, was the waterfall clearing she knew from the autumn when they'd tracked a lost dog from the northern estate. The waterfall. And behind it, a place she'd noticed once and not gone into because there hadn't been a reason yet.

"Case number two," Elizabeth said. "The pulsing compass. We go in the morning."

"It should have a scarier name."

"The Mysterious Pulsing Compass?"

Scarlet considered. "Better. Still a bit administrative."

"In the morning," Elizabeth said, going back to bed, "we can discuss naming conventions. For now, stop talking so I can think about logistics."

She heard Scarlet turn over on the top bunk. Then, quietly:

"Elizabeth?"

"Yes."

"I'm glad we told the truth."

A pause. "Me too," Elizabeth said.

She lay in the dark and listened to the compass pulse and let herself feel, for the first time in weeks, simply ready for whatever came next.

In the morning, they packed backpacks with the thoroughness of professionals. Max saw the backpacks. He saw the extra marshmallows Scarlet was sliding in beside the water bottles. He saw the compass in Elizabeth's front pocket and he did not ask where they were going. He handed them each a cheese roll from the morning basket and said, "Be back before dinner," and went back to his morning routine.

Which meant he knew and approved, or he knew and had decided to let it happen, or he genuinely had not noticed, and of those three options, the first two were by far the most likely.

The woods were quiet in the early morning, the way places are when most of the world hasn't arrived yet. The compass pulsed faster as they moved deeper, the rhythm picking up until it was thumping like something impatient rather than something waiting. They followed the path to the waterfall clearing — the falls white and loud, filling the morning air with cold spray and the smell of fresh water — and then Elizabeth held the compass directly in front of her and it pointed, unmistakably, behind the water.

Through the falling water itself.

"Please tell me caves normally have heartbeats," Scarlet said, watching the purple mist that was curling around the base of the falls in a color that matched nothing in nature.

"I don't think they do," Elizabeth said.

They looked at the water.

They looked at each other.

They stepped through.

The Egg in the Mist

Behind the waterfall, the world became something else.

The sound changed first — the roar cut off so completely it felt like going deaf, replaced by the lower hum of water falling on stone, and then below that, something Elizabeth couldn't name immediately. A vibration more than a sound, the way a very large instrument sounds from directly beside it when it's playing the lowest note it has.

The mist curled around their ankles as they stepped in, purple-grey and cool, clinging to their shoes. Drops from the falls hung in the air in a loose constellation behind them, catching the light from the cave entrance and making tiny cold sparks. The cave didn't feel cold. That was the unexpected thing. After the spray of the falls, the interior was warm — not the warmth of fire or breath but the warmth of stone that had been heated slowly and thoroughly from somewhere beneath.

The compass throbbed.

Not pulsing anymore. Throbbing, like something urgent, like a message being sent through a medium that had limits. Thump-thump. Thump-thump.

The same rhythm as the walls.

Because the walls were doing it too.

Elizabeth stopped walking and pressed one hand flat against the nearest crystal-studded surface and felt it through her palm — a steady, living vibration, as if the cave were breathing.

"The walls are beating," Scarlet said, behind her.

"I know."

"Like a heart."

"I know."

"That is not," Scarlet said carefully, "a thing that walls do."

"I know that as well."

They followed the sound deeper, past the stone table where they'd found the brass owl, through a narrowing in the passage that they hadn't noticed before because they hadn't been looking for it, and then out into a second chamber. Smaller than the first, the ceiling lower, the crystal growth here dense and continuous. The purple light was stronger. In the center of the chamber, built up from the floor in a construction of old dark stone that was partly natural and partly arranged, was a nest.

And in the nest was an egg.

It was the size of a beach ball. The shell was smooth and seamless, the color shifting between deep emerald and a rich hammered gold as they moved around it, the pigment changing with the angle the way a dragonfly's wing changes, like the color was a property of the material rather than something on

the surface. From inside it, through the shell, warm light pulsed in the same rhythm as the walls, as the compass.

"Is it a bird?" Scarlet asked.

"Maybe."

"A very, very large bird?"

"Maybe."

"Elizabeth." Scarlet's voice was almost inaudible. "Is it a dinosaur?"

Elizabeth looked at the shell. At the warm light inside it. At the gold and green of it, and the velvet texture of the nest that had been built with apparent care, and the temperature of the air around it, which was noticeably warmer than the rest of the cave. "I don't think it's a dinosaur," she said.

"Then what is it?"

"Something that doesn't have a category yet," Elizabeth said, which was both honest and completely useless as an answer.

Scarlet reached out her hand toward the egg, moving so slowly it was barely movement at all, and when her fingertips touched the shell, the throbbing changed. Faster. More emphatic. Not afraid — nothing in the quality of it suggested fear — but responsive, definitely, like a pulse that sped up because it noticed.

"It knows I'm here," Scarlet breathed.

"We don't know that."

The egg throbbed faster. Thump-thump-thump.

"It knows I'm here," Scarlet said again. She looked at Elizabeth, and her eyes were bright with something that wasn't quite wonder and wasn't quite terror but lived directly between them. "It likes me."

"That's a significant conclusion from limited data."

The egg throbbed faster still.

"Elizabeth."

"I agree that the evidence is suggestive," Elizabeth said.

They stayed for hours.

They sat on the cave floor and made up names for what might be inside: a phoenix, a mountain swan, a kind of stone-lizard that no one had catalogued, a glitter turtle of unknown origin, a very confused bird that had gotten extremely lost, a royal chicken the size of a sofa. Scarlet suggested the last one with complete seriousness and Elizabeth wrote it down, because sometimes the wrong guess still tells you something about the range.

Elizabeth documented everything in the notebook with the thoroughness of someone who understood that what you were seeing might never be seen again and was doing her best to do it justice.

Shell diameter, estimated. Surface temperature, noted qualitatively. Vibration frequency, counted. Color variation notes. Nest materials.

"Can we come back?" Scarlet asked, when they finally got to their feet. Her hand had been resting on the shell for the last twenty minutes and she withdrew it slowly.

"Yes," Elizabeth said.

"Every day?"

"We'll figure out a schedule."

Scarlet looked back at the egg one more time, standing in the entrance to the inner chamber, the purple light warm on her face. "We're coming back," she told the egg, which was either the right thing to say or completely irrelevant and felt, in the moment, like neither.

They were almost to the waterfall curtain when they heard it.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

The lightest possible sound. From the egg, behind them. Something on the inside of the shell.

Tapping out.

They ran all the way home. Not from fear. From the specific joy of knowing that tomorrow would be extraordinary.

Cinder Hatches

They skipped breakfast.

Not in the guilty, something-went-wrong way they had skipped it after Operation Ice Cream, but in the urgent, wonderful, world-is-about-to-be-different way that makes food feel beside the point. They were dressed before dawn, moving around the room in their coordinated quiet, packing with the efficiency of people who have done this enough times to know what matters.

Milk, in the thermal flask. Marshmallows, the whole bag. A blanket — the one from Scarlet's bunk, soft and large. The camera. The notebook. Spare batteries. And a wrapped cheese sandwich for Max, because he was going to see them leaving with a fully packed backpack and the expression of people who had somewhere to be, and a sandwich was the fastest language for we know what we're doing, please let us do it.

Max took the sandwich without comment.

"Science," he said, looking at the backpack.

"Sort of," Elizabeth said.

"Be careful," Max said, and went back to the breakfast arrangements. This was, in its own way, permission.

* * *

The egg was moving when they got there.

Not the subtle throbbing of the previous days — this was visible, physical movement, the whole shell shifting a few degrees one way and then back, like something testing its options. The cracks appeared while they were still coming through the narrowing passage into the inner chamber: a single line, hairline thin, running from the crown of the shell toward the equator, catching the crystal light and glowing along its length with a warm orange.

"It's happening," Scarlet whispered.

She grabbed Elizabeth's arm. Both of them stopped moving, as if any additional motion might disturb something balanced on the edge of a very important moment.

Crack. The orange glow along the fracture brightened.

Then: CRACK. A louder sound, a proper splitting sound, and the top section of the shell — a rough ovoid the size of a dinner plate — simply detached and rolled sideways into the moss. Light poured from the opening, warm gold, filling the chamber and turning the purple crystals amber.

A small shape tumbled out.

It was covered in what appeared to be a translucent membrane that was already drying at the edges, and under the membrane, as they both leaned forward instinctively, were scales. Not fish-scales — these

were overlapping and geometric and caught the light in two colors at once, a deep emerald and a gold that shimmered between light and dark as the creature moved. Which it was doing: moving, shakily, finding its four legs one at a time and testing them against the moss with the uncertain application of someone who had the theory of walking but not yet the practice.

It had a tail. A long, articulated tail, currently uncurled and finding its length. It had wings — small, folded close against its body, and the membrane of them was the softest possible grey-green, like the inner surface of a new leaf.

It had tiny gold horns. Just two, symmetrical, no bigger than her thumb, curving back from its brow with the confidence of things that knew what they were for even if they hadn't decided how to use them yet.

And when it lifted its head and opened its eyes, the eyes were violet. The deep, saturated violet of certain flowers at dusk, the violet of certain sky-edges in winter, a color so specific it seemed impossible to have occurred naturally and also looked like it couldn't have been anything else.

It looked at them.

"Dragon," Elizabeth whispered.

"Baby dragon," Scarlet whispered back. "Specifically. It matters that it's a baby."

The baby dragon considered them. Then it sneezed.

A puff of golden-silver smoke emerged from its nose, thick and sparkling, dissipating in the cave air as tiny points of light. It smelled of warm metal and something sweet — not quite marshmallows but adjacent to marshmallows, like a cousin of the smell rather than the thing itself.

It sneezed again. More sparkling smoke. The smoke left tiny glitter residue on everything in a six-inch radius.

Then it chirped.

It was the smallest sound. High and clear and warm, and absolutely nothing about it suggested anything dangerous or frightening, and everything about it suggested something that had just arrived in the world and was pleased to find it contained people.

"He likes us," Scarlet said. Not a question. A fact.

"We don't know the gender," Elizabeth said.

"He likes us," Scarlet said, exactly the same way.

She held out her hand, palm up, the way you hold your hand for a dog you want to let smell you first. The dragon looked at it for three full seconds. Then it waddled forward — waddled genuinely, still calibrating its gait, its tail sweeping the moss in a wide uncertain arc — and pressed its head into Scarlet's palm.

It fit there perfectly. The golden horns pressed lightly against the base of her fingers, and its scales against her skin were warm, like something that had been in sunlight.

"He likes you," Elizabeth said.

"I told you," Scarlet said, and her voice came out lower than usual, careful, the way you speak when you are trying not to disturb a very important thing.

They spent the afternoon learning what the dragon ate (silver moss, tried and rejected; cheese sandwich, tried and rejected; marshmallows, discovered with an enthusiasm that resulted in Scarlet losing three to a tiny but surprisingly fast set of jaws); what he did not like (loud sounds, camera flash, anything that moved faster than he'd anticipated); what his smoke smelled like at different temperatures (toasted marshmallows when calm, something sharper and more complex when alarmed, glitter in both cases).

"We can't bring him to the castle," Elizabeth said, eventually.

Scarlet had known this was coming. She'd been sidling away from the conversation all afternoon. "I know."

"The castle has curtains. And wooden furniture. And tapestries."

"And Dad's eyebrows," Scarlet said.

"I'm sorry?"

"They're very expressive. Very... flammable-looking. Very prominent." She looked at the dragon with great fondness. "We come every day. The cave is perfect. He has the crystals and the moss and the waterfall. We just come every day."

"Yes," Elizabeth said. That was the simple answer and also the right one.

"He needs a name," Scarlet said.

They tried names all afternoon. Glimmer, which he did not respond to. Jax, which got nothing. Ember, which he considered briefly and then dismissed by walking to the other side of the chamber. Aurelius, which Elizabeth had suggested carefully, just to see. Sir Smoke-a-Lot, which Scarlet had suggested with complete sincerity. The dragon had ignored all of them with the benign composure of someone not hearing their name because it hadn't been said yet.

Then Scarlet reached down and picked up a piece of the eggshell. The one that had rolled away when it opened. It was blackened on the inside, charred by the warmth of whatever had hatched from it. Cinder-black, light and brittle and warm even now.

"Cinder," she said.

The dragon's head came up.

His violet eyes fixed on her with an attention that was immediate and total.

"Cinder," Elizabeth repeated.

The dragon chirped — a pure, resonant note, different from all the previous ones — flapped both wings at once in a motion that was clearly the first time he'd done this deliberately, and the force of it was sufficient to send him rolling backward onto the moss.

He lay there on his back, wings spread, tail curled up, looking at the ceiling with an expression of mild surprise.

Scarlet burst out laughing. Elizabeth pressed her face into her hand and let the laugh come. The cave echoed it back in soft repeating ripples.

Cinder righted himself with dignity, arranged himself on his four legs, and sneezed glitter.

He had chosen his name.

The Marshmallow Feast

Cinder's first problem, approximately twenty minutes after deciding on his name, was hunger. His stomach made a sound that was small in volume and enormous in effect — a low, reverberating rumble that came from somewhere central in his small body and made three of the nearest crystal clusters vibrate sympathetically.

"He's hungry," Scarlet said.

"Yes," Elizabeth said. "I'm aware." She was already opening the notebook to a fresh investigation page. "The question is what he eats."

"Things."

"Specific things. We can't just feed him everything we have and hope something sticks."

"That is literally how you figure out what something eats when you don't have a reference book."

Elizabeth looked at her. She was right, which was slightly annoying. "Trial and error," she said. "Systematic trial and error."

The cheese sandwich failed immediately. Cinder sniffed it, sneezed approximately eleven particles of glitter onto it, and moved away. The silver moss failed even faster — he picked it up in his jaws and put it back down with an expression of polite but definitive rejection. The water from Elizabeth's bottle he accepted, but without enthusiasm, in the way someone drinks because they're supposed to rather than because they want to.

Then Scarlet opened the marshmallow bag.

The sound the bag made — that particular soft papery sound of a marshmallow bag being opened — reached Cinder from six feet away, and his head came up, and his violet eyes went immediately, completely wide. His tail snapped upright. His wings spread approximately four inches and then refolded. He waddled across the cave moss in a straight line, tripped on his tail, recovered, and was sitting directly in front of Scarlet's hand by the time she had the bag properly open.

"Marshmallows," Scarlet said, as if announcing a discovery. "Evidence suggests strongly yes."

Elizabeth was already writing. They poured a small measure of milk from the thermal flask into the camping pot they'd brought for exactly this possibility, added three marshmallows, and Elizabeth reached for the small flint lighter from the kit.

Cinder leaned in.

He breathed.

A thin stream of golden fire, narrow and precise as a candle flame, emerged from his small mouth and touched the bottom of the pot. The milk warmed almost instantly — faster than a stovetop, faster than anything — and the marshmallows puffed upward in the heat, softening from white solids into translucent, yielding domes of sweetness. The fire cut off the exact moment the milk reached

temperature, as if Cinder had an internal thermometer and used it as a matter of course.

"He made hot cocoa," Scarlet said.

"He warmed milk with marshmallows," Elizabeth said. "It is close to hot cocoa."

"He made it. That's the point."

They poured the result into the small camp cup and offered it to Cinder. He drank with a speed and thoroughness that made the cup tremble in Scarlet's hands. The sounds he made while drinking were not dignified. They were extremely enthusiastic.

When the cup was empty, he sat back on his haunches and blinked, and his expression — and dragons, it turned out, had extremely readable expressions — was the precise expression of a person who has had something so exactly right that the universe briefly organizes itself around the rightness of it.

"Every day," Scarlet said. "We visit every day. That's the deal."

"That's a significant logistical commitment," Elizabeth said.

"Non-negotiable."

It became clear within the week that every day was going to require some inventiveness. The milk had to come from the kitchen, which was large enough and busy enough that small quantities could leave without comment, but the marshmallows were a different matter — they were specialty stock, ordered from a confectioner who supplied the castle bakery, and when Elizabeth came down to the kitchen on the third morning with a bag large enough to fill both arms, the cook — a broad, efficient woman named Mrs. Guthrie who noticed everything in her domain — asked no question but set her spatula down and watched the bag exit through the kitchen door with the expression of someone making a mental note.

Three days later, Max appeared at the girls' bedroom door at exactly the right moment.

"That is a very large bag," he said, looking at the marshmallow supply.

"School project," Elizabeth said.

"About marshmallows?"

"It's science."

Max looked at the bag. Looked at the girls. Looked at the window that faced, if you followed the line of sight far enough, the general direction of the Whispering Woods.

"Science," he said, "can be quite sticky." A pause. "Be careful."

He stepped aside.

In the cave, Cinder was growing stronger every day. His wings stretched wider with each afternoon — you could watch the growth almost in real time, the way you could watch a flower open if you sat with it long enough. His fire became more controlled. He could warm milk in thirty seconds now, and when he was happy, which was often, he made small practice flames that lit the crystals from underneath and turned the whole cave warm amber.

When he curled up in the silver moss after his afternoon marshmallow session, full and content, the cave felt like the kind of place you'd want to come back to.

"We'll protect you," Scarlet told him, one Thursday, sitting with her back against the cave wall and Cinder's head in her lap. His breathing had gone slow and deep, the small chest rising and falling. "Royal Detective promise."

Cinder opened one violet eye, considered her, and hummed.

Elizabeth looked up from the notebook.

The cave wall shimmered.

It was very fast — a second, maybe less — but unmistakable: the crystal surface reflected something that wasn't the cave. Two figures, walking. The woods behind them, recognizable. Earlier that same day, before they'd arrived.

Then it was gone.

Elizabeth grabbed the notebook and opened it to a fresh page.

"Cinder," she said, "can do something we haven't recorded yet."

Scarlet looked at the wall. At Cinder's closed violet eyes. At the cave.

"Case two," she said quietly, "just got more interesting."

Echo-Vision

They called it Echo-Vision because "magic cave movie eyes" was, as Scarlet pointed out, impractical to say in a crisis, and all their best investigative tools had names that fit in a single breath.

Cinder produced it the way he produced most things: apparently by thinking about it, without visible mechanism, with the calm confidence of someone doing something that was, to him, entirely natural. He hummed a specific tone — lower than his usual hum, with a quality to it that resonated in the crystals differently — and the cave wall shimmered, and then showed things.

Past things, specifically. Things that had happened in the vicinity of the cave, in the world around the cave, in some undefined radius that they hadn't yet been able to determine. The images were clear and steady, no distortion, slightly warmer in color than real life, like a photograph taken at golden hour.

At first it was genuinely funny.

He showed Scarlet tripping over a root on the forest path four times in a row, each replay slightly further zoomed in, as if he were enjoying it. He showed Elizabeth making her thinking face while holding a marshmallow bag upside down, which was a face she did not know she made and found objectionable. He showed Max, one week prior, standing at the edge of the wood with his arms folded, looking at the waterfall from twenty feet away with the expression of a man doing very precise calculations about whether to go closer.

"He doesn't come in," Elizabeth said, watching the replay. "He knows it's here."

"He knows a lot of things and waits," Scarlet said. "He does that."

But Echo-Vision stopped being funny when the image changed without Cinder being asked.

His hum shifted — the note went lower, more deliberate — and the wall showed something they hadn't asked for. A figure, moving through the forest. Cloaked, not Max, with a different gait entirely: longer stride, purposeful, moving through the trees with the confidence of someone who had been there before. On the figure's sleeve, for one flash of reflected light, Elizabeth saw a small silver mark: a circle crossed by a net. The figure stopped at the edge of the waterfall clearing, stood for a long time looking at the falls, and then — and this was the part that made the cave feel smaller, suddenly — looked directly at the cliff face where the cave entrance was concealed behind vines.

Not toward the vines. At the specific location of the vines. As if they weren't there.

"When is that?" Elizabeth asked. Her voice was very level.

Cinder hummed lower still, and the image shifted to show the angle of the sun through the trees. Elizabeth looked at the shadows.

"This morning," she said. "This was this morning."

"Someone was here," Scarlet said.

"Someone who knows where the cave is."

Cinder had pulled his wings tight against his sides, a posture they were beginning to recognize. He was alarmed.

"We have to make it harder to find," Elizabeth said.

The plan happened quickly, because it needed to. Cinder seemed to understand — his cooperation was immediate, specific, and more skilled than they'd expected from something that had been alive for less than two weeks. He waddled to the vine curtain at the cave entrance and breathed, and what came out was not fire.

Silver mist.

Thick and particular, the consistency of dense fog, and it moved with intention rather than diffusing normally. It spread over the entrance in a layer, and where it touched stone it thickened and held, like paint drying at about twenty times the normal speed. The girls packed rocks and moss around and into it, and Cinder moved along the edges with small pulses of golden heat that bonded everything into a surface that looked, from two feet away, like cliff.

From across the clearing, it looked like nothing. Like the cliff had always been exactly that. No vines, no cave entrance, no mist. Just stone.

"Invisible wall," Scarlet said.

"Disguised," Elizabeth said.

"Invisible sounds better."

"Disguised is more accurate."

"Cinder," Scarlet said, "which sounds better?"

Cinder, who was sitting behind them examining the result of their work with the professional interest of an artisan reviewing a product, chirped.

"Invisible wins," Scarlet said.

Elizabeth noted both terms in the notebook.

They were still admiring the work — still running their hands along the seamless surface, testing it from different angles, checking how it looked from the tree line — when the first knock came.

Thump.

From the other side of the wall they'd just built.

They froze. Cinder went very still.

Thump. Thump.

Heavy. Deliberate. Not exploratory — the knock of someone who knew a wall was there and was announcing themselves to whoever was behind it.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

Elizabeth and Scarlet looked at each other. In the silence between knocks, the cave held every sound very carefully.

The knock was patient. It would wait.

It had, apparently, all the time it needed.

The Face Beyond Stone

No one breathed.

The cave had its own sounds — crystals adjusting to temperature, the distant white noise of the waterfall, Cinder's soft respiration — and under all of them, the knock. Patient as something that had thought about this moment and decided not to rush it.

Scarlet pulled Cinder into the shadows by the far crystal cluster, tucking herself down to his level, her arm around his neck. His scales were warm and slightly tense, his wings pressed close. Elizabeth clicked off the flashlight. In the darkness, the cave's own light took over: the faint glow of the crystals, and Cinder's eyes, open and violet and steady.

The knock came again.

And then, muffled by stone but entirely clear: "Royal Detectives."

Scarlet's head turned in the dark. Her expression, lit in violet: Is that...

Elizabeth held up a hand. Could be a trick. Detectives did not open secret walls for anyone who sounded like their butler. That was a specific and learnable mistake.

Cinder moved.

He waddled to the center of the wall and sat down, and hummed his Echo-Vision tone, and the wall shimmered.

But instead of showing the past, it showed the present. The person on the other side, rendered in blue light like an X-ray image projected through stone: height and build and posture and, unmistakably, the precise curling mustache, the perfectly aligned jacket, the something-in-the-hand that resolved, as the image clarified, into a canvas apron over one arm and a tool kit in the other.

Max. Outside. Waiting.

Elizabeth let out a breath she hadn't planned to hold.

"He can see through walls now," Scarlet said. "Cinder, you absolute wonder."

They found the secret push-point — a small depression in the new wall's surface, the one intentional weakness — and pressed it, and a section the size of a narrow door swung inward.

Max stepped through.

He took in the cave with the unhurried comprehensive gaze he used when he was cataloguing information for future reference. The crystals. The stone table. The remains of the afternoon's milk session. Cinder, sitting in the center of the space, watching him with violet eyes and the specific alert posture of something that hasn't decided yet.

"A dragon," Max said.

"A baby dragon," Scarlet said.

"Named Cinder," Elizabeth added.

"He's been here since we found the egg," Scarlet said. "He hatched here. We've been coming every day. We didn't tell you because—"

"Because dragons are not traditionally in the category of things you mention to authority figures before you understand the situation," Max said. He was still looking at Cinder, and his expression was doing something unusual: it was doing several things at once, as if the information was being processed in parallel. "How long ago did he hatch?"

"Eleven days," Elizabeth said.

"And the Echo-Vision?"

"You knew about the Echo-Vision?"

"I knew it was a property of certain crystal formations near certain kinds of magical heat sources," Max said. "I did not know it was already operational." He moved his gaze to the wall — their disguised wall — and ran one gloved finger along the seam. "The mist seal. He did this?"

"With our help," Scarlet said. "The rocks and moss were us. The mist was him."

Max stepped back. He removed his goggles from his forehead and looked at them properly and then set them back. "The castle sensors," he said, "picked up a dragon heartbeat twelve days ago. I assumed I was misreading the output. Sensors are very rarely wrong, which is the inconvenient part of relying on them."

"Are you going to tell?" Elizabeth asked.

The question landed in the cave and stayed there.

Max looked at Cinder again. Cinder, who had been watching all of this with the patience of something that understood more than it showed, sneezed once — small, controlled, a puff of glitter smoke that drifted over Max's shoe and settled there in tiny sparkling points.

Max looked at his shoe.

"No," he said. "The castle has people in it who would not understand the difference between a dragon and a threat. The King employs scouts whose job it is to report unusual wildlife in the kingdom's forests. The kingdom itself has people who collect unusual things." He looked at Cinder with the specific focused attention of someone making a decision. "A dragon this young and this unguarded is safest exactly where he is and known about by exactly no one who doesn't already know."

Elizabeth felt something loosen in her chest. "So you'll help?"

"I can manage the castle sensors. I can provide adequate cover for your supply runs. I can build what needs building." He glanced at the marshmallow supply with an expression that was the closest Max's face came to finding something amusing. "I can probably also explain the marshmallow budget, which is becoming difficult to account for."

Cinder stood up. He walked, with deliberation, across the cave floor to Max's feet. He sniffed the rainbow tie, which had been visible under the canvas apron the whole time and which Cinder had apparently been curious about since Max entered. He sniffed it thoroughly, making a small investigative

sound.

Then he sneezed glitter onto both of Max's shoes.

Max looked down at his glittering shoes.

"He likes you," Scarlet said. "That's how he says it."

"I'm deeply honored," Max said, with the exact sincerity of someone who meant it completely and had chosen a flat delivery anyway.

The secret team stood in the glowing cave, the crystals warm around them, the waterfall a distant roar, and took stock of what they were.

Three humans, one baby dragon, and a disguised wall that looked like cliff face.

It was, Elizabeth wrote in the notebook that night, adequate for now.

The Stealth Flight

Cinder grew the way things grow when they have exactly what they need: steadily, visibly, with the particular confidence of something following a blueprint that fits.

His wings were the most obvious evidence. In the first week they had been soft and folded and uncertain, like new leaves that hadn't found their shape yet. By the second week they stretched at his sides when he walked, bumping into crystal formations, catching on things. By the third week, after Max had joined the operation and the daily milk-and-marshmallow delivery had become a smooth routine, the wings were spreading fully when Cinder moved through the inner chamber, and the inner chamber was no longer quite big enough for him to do it without consequence.

He knocked over the milk pot twice. He swept Scarlet's notebook into the waterfall entrance once. He moved a six-inch crystal off its formation by accident, which surprised both of them — the crystal had been in that formation for what appeared to be a very long time.

"He needs to fly," Scarlet said.

"He needs to not be seen flying," Elizabeth said.

Max arrived that afternoon with a small case. Inside were two metal bracelets, thin and light, with a tiny mechanism on each that he adjusted with a tool from his apron. "Proximity detectors," he said. "Tuned to the nearest castle sensor array. They buzz when a scout comes within two hundred meters." He also produced, from the same case, a pair of inventor's goggles scaled down to dragon size, which he said he'd built out of curiosity and hadn't expected to need this quickly.

The goggles were for Cinder. Cinder ate the strap and then wore them anyway, which Max noted was probably sufficient.

"When do we go?" Scarlet asked.

"Late afternoon," Elizabeth said. "When the waterfall mist is thickest. The mist will disperse his fire glow and make him harder to see from the castle walls."

"And he needs to fly low," Max said. "Below the tree line. The scouts are watching the upper airspace."

"He can't go too high?" Scarlet asked.

"He can," Max said. "The concern is whether he should." He looked at Cinder with the evaluating gaze of someone whose experience of assessing capability was more professional than sentimental. "He could go significantly higher than the tree line. Considerably higher. Possibly quite high indeed."

Cinder sneezed cheerfully.

"Low," Elizabeth said.

Late afternoon came with a mist from the waterfall that filled the clearing in thick rolling layers, the light through it turning golden-amber, the trees above it disappearing into white. It was good cover. It

was perhaps the best available cover. It was the kind of afternoon that in children's stories would be described as magical, which was accurate, and was also about to have an actual dragon in it.

Cinder stood at the cave entrance and vibrated.

Not the anxiety vibration — the excitement one. They were different enough that both girls could tell them apart now, the way you learned to distinguish sounds from someone you spent enough time with. This was joy-before-action, the particular trembling of something about to become exactly what it was designed to be.

"Low," Elizabeth said. "Under the trees. No fire. No loops. Nothing dramatic."

Cinder looked at her.

"I see that look," Elizabeth said. "It is not a look of agreement. Try again."

Cinder looked at her again. The second look was very similar to the first look.

"He says he'll consider it," Scarlet said.

"He didn't say anything."

"He said it with his eyes."

Cinder breathed golden fog. A long, controlled exhale of it, mixing with the waterfall mist, turning the clearing a warm amber-white. Then he crouched, and launched.

He dropped first. For one heart-stopping second he simply fell, straight down, and Elizabeth's hand came up as if she could catch him, and then his wings snapped open — fully open, for the first time, the full span of them catching the air under the waterfall mist — and he rose.

He flew.

It was not the competent, controlled flight of an experienced creature. It was the flight of someone discovering, in real time, that they could do the thing they were made for, and the discovery was so immediate and so large that it temporarily consumed all available processing capacity. He wobbled. He listed left. He overcorrected right. He hit a draft from the falls that sent him sideways and his expression, visible from below, was pure astonished delight.

"He's doing it!" Scarlet's voice went up in pitch by about four notes. She was running along below him on the forest floor, tracking his path. "Elizabeth, he's actually—"

"Quietly," Elizabeth said, also running.

Cinder skimmed above the ferns. The golden fog around him caught the light and turned him into a drift of warm luminescence, almost invisible from a distance, beautiful from close. He sneezed mid-flight — the glitter scattered behind him like a comet trail — and three birds exploded from a nearby ash tree in indignant protest.

Scarlet's bracelet buzzed.

Two short bursts. Elizabeth's answered immediately.

"Someone's coming," Elizabeth hissed.

Scarlet gave the birdcall — a short, specific sequence that in all honesty sounded nothing like a bird and more like someone experiencing moderate surprise, but which Cinder had somehow learned to recognize as a signal. He dropped, fast and deliberate, and folded himself into a stand of bracken ferns fifteen feet away.

Elizabeth and Scarlet stopped walking. They went still the way you go still when the stillness matters.

The royal scout appeared through the trees from the north path. He was in standard uniform, doing a routine sweep of the forest edge, and he moved slowly the way people move when they're paying attention to the landscape. He stopped at the edge of the clearing. He looked at the golden mist.

"Strange weather," he muttered.

From the ferns, approximately twelve feet from the man's boot, Cinder's tail extended slowly into the open and then, as Scarlet's foot found it and applied gentle pressure, retracted.

The scout looked at the mist for a moment longer, then moved on.

They waited a full two minutes after his footsteps faded.

Cinder emerged from the ferns with a leaf on each horn and a very dignified expression.

"First flight," Elizabeth wrote, in her notebook, her hand still slightly trembling. "Successful." Then added, from Scarlet's dictation: "First hiding — needs practice."

She closed the notebook. High above the tree line — so far up you'd call it a bird if you didn't look closely, and if you did look closely it still moved like a bird, but with the smooth mechanical precision of something that had a plan — a shape circled twice. Caught the afternoon light on something that was not feathers.

Its wing flashed silver. For one cold instant, Elizabeth saw the same mark from the Echo-Vision: a circle crossed by a net.

Elizabeth watched it.

"Cinder didn't fly that high," she said.

Scarlet followed her gaze. The shape had already moved on, crossing into the castle's eastern airspace. "No," she said. "He didn't."

They looked at each other.

Case number two, Elizabeth thought, had at least one more layer to it.

She opened the notebook back to a fresh page.

The Royal Hawaiian Jet

The Hawaii announcement happened at breakfast, which was where all the significant announcements in the family happened, on the theory that no one could react dramatically while eating.

Mom put down her tea cup, in the particular way she put things down when she had something to say, and said: "We're going to Hawaii. Two weeks. All of us."

Scarlet's spoon hit the bowl.

Elizabeth paused mid-pour with the orange juice and then set the pitcher down carefully.

Dad spread a map across the table — the large paper kind, which he always preferred over digital because he said you couldn't feel the distance on a screen — and tapped a point in the middle of the Pacific with some enthusiasm. "Sun," he said. "Beaches. Volcanic coastline. Sea caves. Cultural history." He looked up. "Absolutely no detective emergencies."

Max, standing at the sideboard, coughed into a napkin.

It was a very specific cough. The kind that was not about clearing a throat.

He was wearing the pineapple tie.

Scarlet looked at it. Elizabeth looked at it. Max looked at absolutely nothing in particular.

"Tropical emergencies," Scarlet whispered.

* * *

The logistical problem was immediate and obvious and it had a name and the name was Cinder.

They couldn't leave him. They couldn't bring him on a commercial jet. They couldn't tell the staff. They couldn't leave a self-sufficient dragon in an unsupervised cave for two weeks when someone was apparently already looking for him, because they had seen the mechanical bird twice now and once was unusual and twice was a pattern and patterns meant someone with resources and patience.

"We need a way to bring him," Scarlet said, sitting cross-legged on the Ladybug Room floor with her chin in her hands. "Without anyone knowing. Without him burning anything. Without him eating anything structural."

"He ate the goggles strap," Elizabeth noted.

"He gave the goggles back. Mostly."

Max solved it three days before the flight, appearing in the room with a trunk.

It looked like a royal travel trunk — dark wood banded with brass, the crest of the household on the lid, the kind of luggage that got handled respectfully and loaded first. Inside, however, was something else entirely: a warming pad that ran off a battery concealed in the base; ventilation channels cut into the brass banding, disguised as decoration; a sealed compartment on the side that held a flask of milk and a

small wrapped portion of marshmallows; and on the lid, painted in very small letters: DO NOT EAT THE HINGES.

"He ate the prototype's hinges," Max said, by way of explanation.

Cinder, when introduced to the trunk, examined it thoroughly, ate a small piece of interior lining, decided it was acceptable, and climbed in.

The flight was everything Elizabeth had expected and also several things she hadn't.

Cinder loved the clouds. This expressed itself as a sustained vibration from inside the trunk, accompanied by the muffled chirping of something deeply pleased. The trunk had to be checked as oversized baggage and loaded through the private jet's cargo compartment, but they were cleared to be near it, and Scarlet spent significant portions of the flight on the floor beside it feeding marshmallows through the ventilation channel that was — not coincidentally — at exactly the right height for a small dragon.

"Why does the luggage smell like toasted sugar?" Dad said, from the front of the jet, at some point over the Pacific.

"Travel snacks," Max said, without looking up from his journal.

"In the luggage?"

"I keep them very accessible," Max said.

The island arrived below them as the sun was setting, which meant they landed in the hour when everything was the color of embers, the water deep blue in the distance and green closer to shore, and the smell when the cabin door opened was salt and flowers and warm stone. The kind of arrival that made you forget you were tired.

They were at the beach the next morning.

The beach had the particular quality that Hawaiian beaches have: the feeling of being simultaneously very old and very immediate, the lava rock and the sand and the palms and the green water all arranged as if by something with better taste than anything manufactured. Elizabeth was standing at the edge of the vegetation, looking at the cliffs at the far end of the beach, when Scarlet appeared beside her.

And then someone else appeared in front of them.

She was their age. She had a surfboard under one arm, the easy carry of someone who'd been doing it for long enough that the board had become an extension rather than an object. Her skin was warm brown, her hair sun-lightened and loose, and around her neck she wore a necklace of sea glass — smoothed and pale and green, the color of old bottles found by the tide.

She looked at them for a moment with the assessing gaze of someone who grew up in a place where people came from elsewhere all the time and had developed an efficient system for knowing which ones were worth talking to.

"You're staring at the cliffs," she said.

"We like cliffs," Scarlet said.

"Most tourists like the water." She shifted the board slightly. "You're not looking at the water."

"We like caves," Elizabeth added.

The girl studied them. Something changed in her expression, slightly, in the direction of interest. "Those cliffs," she said, nodding toward the far end of the beach, "are not ordinary cliffs. People call them the Whispering Tides. When the wind comes from the east, they make sounds."

"What kind of sounds?" Scarlet asked.

"Depends who you ask." She set the surfboard in the sand, which was the posture of someone settling in for a real conversation. "My grandmother says they're the old guardians, speaking. Other people say it's the sea caves under the rock. Scientists say pressure and acoustics." She looked at them. "I think the scientists and the grandmother are both right."

"What is your name?" Elizabeth asked.

"Leilani," the girl said.

Above them, crossing the blue morning sky at the altitude of a large bird, something metallic caught the light. Leilani looked up sharply. So did Elizabeth.

Elizabeth's Vibe-Link — the bracelet Max had tuned — buzzed once.

She looked at the shape in the sky. At Leilani, who had seen it too and was watching it with an expression that was not surprise.

"Silver Net," Leilani said, so quietly Elizabeth almost missed it.

Vacation had lasted eleven minutes before something happened.

Eleven minutes was, honestly, better than she'd expected.

Leilani and the Whispering Tides

Leilani knew the island the way Elizabeth knew the castle: not from maps or descriptions or official tours, but from years of particular attention, the kind you can only accumulate by being somewhere enough times in enough conditions to understand it from the inside.

She showed them the tide pools along the lava shelf at the base of the Whispering Tides cliffs — pools full of tiny silver fish that moved in such perfect unison they looked like one large thing — and the black lava rock that was warm from the morning sun even where it was in shade, the heat stored in its dark surface from days and days of light. She showed them a flower that grew only in the crevices between two specific kinds of rock, pink-white and extravagant, which bloomed exactly at noon and closed by two and which she called by a name in Hawaiian that translated roughly to "the late riser."

"The Whispering Tides cave," she told them, as they walked the cliff base toward it, "only opens at low tide. The sea fills it at high tide and empties it at low, which means you have maybe ninety minutes inside before you need to be back at the entrance." She said this with the flat precision of someone who had learned it from experience rather than reading. "My grandmother says the cave was a meeting place. For the old ones."

"What old ones?" Scarlet asked.

Leilani gave them the look she apparently gave all questions that had more than one answer. "Depends who tells the story. Birds in some versions. Spirits in others. Old machines, in my grandfather's version — he was an engineer and believed everything had a mechanical explanation." She paused. "And in my grandmother's version, which she told me last, and which I think is the true one — fire friends. Creatures made of mountain and fire that came from far away and lived in partnership with the people here."

Elizabeth tried not to visibly react to the word dragons.

She was fairly sure she didn't succeed.

Leilani looked at her for just a moment longer than necessary. Then looked away.

* * *

That night, in the villa the royal household had rented for the stay, Elizabeth and Scarlet sat with the trunk in their room and did the math that had been obvious since Leilani mentioned fire friends.

"We have to introduce them," Scarlet said.

"That is a significant decision," Elizabeth said.

"She already knows something. She looked at the bracelet when it buzzed. She recognized the mechanical bird." Scarlet was sitting cross-legged on the bed, reasoning through it. "And she knows about fire friends. That's not coincidence. That's someone who lives in the same story we're in."

"You can't know if someone is trustworthy in one day," Elizabeth said.

"You trusted Max in about ten seconds after he found the broken glass."

"I didn't trust Max. I respected Max's leverage."

"Same thing for the first three weeks," Scarlet said, with accuracy.

As if the conversation itself had been the deciding vote, Cinder sneezed the trunk open.

He had been quiet all day — the trip had been a lot; the thermal padding helped, but travel was travel — and apparently he was done with the quiet. The trunk lid lifted on his outbreath and he emerged blinking, slightly ruffled, and looked around the room with the expression of someone who had been patient long enough.

He saw Leilani, who was standing in the doorway because they'd left it open and she'd knocked but the knock had been covered by the trunk event.

Cinder saw Leilani. Leilani saw Cinder.

A silence.

"This is our travel snack," Scarlet said automatically.

"No," Elizabeth said, closing her eyes briefly, "it is not."

Leilani set her hand on the doorframe. She was doing the same thing Scarlet had done with her palm when she first met him — quiet, still, waiting. "He's beautiful," she said. And then, slower: "My grandmother's fire friends were real."

She sat down on the floor, cross-legged, which put her at Cinder's eye level. He watched her for a full thirty seconds with those violet eyes — this was longer than he'd taken with anyone except Scarlet — and then walked to her and sniffed her sea-glass necklace with evident interest.

"Sea glass," Leilani said. "He can smell the fire in it. Sea glass is made from regular glass that's been through heat and time and water. The fire is very old but it's there."

Cinder chirped.

"He trusts you," Elizabeth said. "That usually takes three marshmallows at minimum."

"What does it take without marshmallows?"

"We don't know. We've never had the data."

They told Leilani everything that night. The vase, the cave, the egg, the hatch, the brass owl, the Clocktower, Max, the disguised wall, the Echo-Vision, the stealth flight, the mechanical bird. She listened the way good listeners listen — without filling the silences, without interrupting to show she understood, just taking in each piece and letting it find its place.

When they were done, she sat with it for a moment.

"There are carvings in the Whispering Tides cave," she said. "Very old. My grandmother tried to explain them to me once. They showed creatures like him" — she looked at Cinder, who was asleep on her feet — "and people. Not the creatures serving the people. Not the people commanding the creatures."

Just — together."

"Partners," Scarlet said.

"Sky guardians," Leilani said.

The next morning, at low tide, all of them went — Cinder flying under a cover of golden fog while they watched the Vibe-Links, Max carrying a beach umbrella and a canvas tote labeled DEFINITELY NOT DRAGON FOOD in Max's precise handwriting. The cave entrance opened at the base of the cliff as Leilani had promised: a wide arch of darkness at the waterline, accessible now that the tide had drawn back, the walls glistening with the salt water they held between tides.

Inside, the lava glass walls reflected everything. The light from the entrance. The glow from Cinder's eyes. And when the sea moved through the hidden channels beneath them — a deep, resonant hum that traveled through the stone and into your feet — Cinder hummed back, a single sustained note, and the two sounds together were something that had no name yet in any language Elizabeth knew.

Then the cave wall shimmered.

Cinder had not hummed the Echo-Vision tone, but the cave answered anyway, as if it had its own memory that didn't need asking. On the black lava glass: dragons in flight. Different from Cinder — larger, older, moving in pairs and groups over this specific island, over the sea, over a world that had more of them in it than this one did. And below them, on the water, people waving from long canoes, their hands up in a gesture that looked like welcome.

"The old ones," Leilani said quietly.

Then the image shifted. Not Cinder's doing. Not theirs. The cave offered it: a metal bird, landing on the cliff above them, and a human figure below it who looked up and waited for it to arrive.

The same mechanical bird they'd been seeing.

Someone had been following the dragon clues for longer than they'd known.

Leilani looked at the image. Then at Cinder. Then at the entrance to the cave, where the tide was beginning to turn.

"We need to know who that is," she said.

"We need to know several things," Elizabeth agreed. "Starting with where the lava glass in this cave points."

She opened the notebook.

Case number two had just grown significantly.

The Lava Glass Map

The cave spoke in maps.

That was what they understood, standing in the Whispering Tides chamber with the tide turning outside and Cinder's violet eyes doing what violet eyes apparently did in the presence of old lava glass: glowing, slowly, with a light that was richer and more deliberate than his ordinary glow, and reaching outward into the black surface of the walls the way roots reach into dark soil.

Golden lines appeared.

They emerged from the glass like writing becoming visible as the ink dries — first barely there, then definite, then bright. They were not random. They connected in the specific purposeful way of something someone had spent a long time designing: a coastline here, a ridge there, a series of marks at the volcano's northeast crater that pulsed brighter than anything else on the map.

Leilani touched the pulsing mark. "Pu'u Ahi," she said. "Fire Hill. The old volcanic crater on the northeast side of the island. Tourists are supposed to stay away from it — the ground's unstable in the southern quadrant — but the northern approach has a cleared trail."

"Maintained by whom?" Elizabeth asked.

Leilani considered. "That's a good question. The park service says they don't maintain it."

"So someone does," Scarlet said.

"Someone does," Leilani agreed.

Max cleared his throat. "I want to be explicit that we are not going to an active volcanic crater area without a plan, a contingency plan, and probably a third plan we haven't thought of yet." He looked at the map. "However, I am not going to suggest we don't go at all, because we clearly have to." A pause. "That said—"

The Vibe-Links buzzed.

Elizabeth had hers on her wrist and felt it before she heard the others. Two short bursts, close together. Close proximity. The range on these was two hundred meters.

The entrance to the cave was forty meters away.

Leilani moved first. She'd seen how the system worked once and apparently only needed to see something once. She went low, toward the interior passage they'd used to get in, one finger pressed to her lips. Max gathered his equipment in one smooth motion, the beach umbrella horizontal, not because it helped and partly because letting go of it was apparently not something he was prepared to do. Elizabeth followed the compass — it was pointing deeper into the cave's interior passage, through the low arch that led to the secondary chamber they'd found on their way in.

Scarlet came last, pulling Cinder along by the gentlest possible persuasion: one marshmallow produced from the bag, held slightly ahead of his nose, leading him through the arch like a very small

and very luminous parade float.

They squeezed through.

Max got stuck at the arch because of the beach umbrella.

"Max," Scarlet hissed.

"A prepared butler—"

"Max."

He let go of the umbrella. It remained upright in the tunnel, which was somehow worse.

The secondary chamber was open to the sky through a natural vent — a narrow vertical crack in the ceiling that let in a column of afternoon light. The floor was older here, darker stone, and at the center of it stood something that looked like a basin: a stone bowl, waist-height, filled not with water but with sand. Very fine sand, intensely blue, the blue of the vase-glass and the note-ink and the compass housing, every blue in this story connecting here in a single full stop.

Cinder walked to the basin without hesitation.

He hummed.

The blue sand rose.

It didn't spill — it rose in a column, dense and revolving, and then it spread outward at the top in a shape that was clearly deliberate rather than random. A harness. Articulated and specific, with the configuration of something designed for a creature with wings and a deep keel chest and a gait that required the shoulders free for flight. A sky guardian's gear, built in blue sand, suspended in the air by Cinder's hum, catching the column of light and turning it into something ceremonial.

"He's supposed to wear it," Scarlet said.

"He's supposed to carry it," Leilani said, more precisely. "The carvings in the cave show the gear being worn. And the guardians in the carvings were carrying things — not weapons. Messages. Objects." She looked at the harness shape. "Sky guardian. A guardian who flies. Who carries. Who delivers."

"A messenger," Elizabeth said.

"And protector," Leilani said. "Both."

From the sand, rising in the same slow deliberate way: one more shape. An object, suspended above the harness. Elizabeth recognized the material before she could name the purpose. Blue glass. Not a missing part of the vase, but the same impossible Dragon Glass, cut into a thin curved key with map-lines shining inside it. The final piece of the map.

Here.

In a volcanic cave in Hawaii.

Connected to the same story they'd started with, six weeks ago in a castle five thousand miles away, with roller skates and a marble floor and a crash that they had believed, at the time, was only a catastrophe.

"It was never just a vase," Elizabeth said.

No one disagreed.

The voices came through the ceiling vent first, slightly muffled by the stone but unmistakably close: two people moving along the exterior cliff, and one of them saying, with the flat professional certainty of someone paid to find things, "The signal came from here."

And the other: "Find the source. The collector pays extra for living specimens."

Cinder's wings flared.

Leilani moved to him, hand on his neck, her voice lower than the waterfall outside. "Quiet, fire friend." And he quieted — not from fear, Elizabeth thought, but from trust, the specific trust you gave people who called you by a name that recognized what you were.

The collector.

Elizabeth looked at Max.

Max looked at the ceiling vent.

"Plan," he said quietly.

"Working on it," Elizabeth said.

"I have the umbrella," Max said.

"That," Elizabeth said, "may actually help."

The Collector's Net

The net came without warning.

One moment the ceiling vent was just a ceiling vent, casting a column of afternoon light into the chamber, and then it was full of silver — a net, dense and fine-mesh, dropping through the opening in a controlled fall, its edges spreading as it fell to cover the maximum possible area.

It fell toward Cinder.

"Move!" Elizabeth's voice came out before thought did.

Cinder tried. He jumped sideways, clearing most of it, but his left wing caught on a crystal formation at exactly the wrong angle — not trapped, but slowed, the membrane against the stone for half a second — and Scarlet was already moving, throwing herself forward and pulling the wing free with both hands, the net hitting the chamber floor where Cinder had been and contracting, the mesh tightening around empty stone and crystal.

The sound it made was wrong. Not the sound of a net. The sound of something that had more in it than fiber and mesh — something in the weave that hummed briefly and then went quiet, a frequency designed for something.

"Back," Max said, from the arch. He'd retrieved the umbrella.

"Collector?" Leilani asked.

"Two of them, from the sound of the footsteps above."

"Silver Net," Elizabeth said.

Max's expression sharpened. "Then they are not curious tourists. They are people who collect rare living things and call it preservation so they can sleep at night."

Leilani reached into her pocket and found a shell — not decorative, a working shell, conch-shaped and large enough to produce sound. She blew into it, once, a single low note that traveled outward through the cave system with remarkable efficiency. From outside, faintly, came the sound of the tide.

The tide that was turning.

"This way," she said, and ran.

They went through the interior of the cave in a configuration that would have been comic if it had been less urgent: Leilani leading, compass-fast through passages she'd navigated enough times to know by feel; Elizabeth behind her following the compass needle; Scarlet immediately behind with Cinder, who was running on his four legs with surprising speed and also sneezing glitter smoke at irregular intervals; Max last, with the beach umbrella, which he was using as a kind of relay baton, extending it ahead to block passage entrances before anyone committed to them.

Behind them: footsteps. Two sets, quick and professional, not panicked — the footsteps of people who did this and expected to catch what they were chasing.

"The creature is valuable," one voice said, carrying through the stone.

"He is not a creature." Scarlet's voice came out compressed with running and full of feeling. "He is Cinder."

"Argue later," Elizabeth said.

They burst through a low exit that put them on a sheltered strip of beach that only existed at exactly this tide, high cliffs on three sides, the sea immediately before them. The waves were coming in already, the ninety-minute window Leilani had described drawing to its close. The only exit that didn't go back the way they'd come was a trail up the cliff face to the left — narrow, clear, accessible if you went one at a time.

Cinder was shaking.

Not the wing-vibration of excitement, not the hum of contentment. Shaking. The net had come close. The instinct it triggered was old and deep and not about dragons who lived in crystal caves with daily marshmallows — it was about something more fundamental, an understanding of what being caught meant.

Elizabeth knelt in front of him on the wet sand.

"Hey," she said. Behind them, the cave entrance darkened with approaching figures. She kept her eyes on Cinder. "Listen. You do not have to be big to be brave. You just have to take the next step. One. That's all."

Violet eyes looked at her.

Cinder breathed out. Long. Slow. The shaking slowed.

From behind the cave entrance, voices. Closer.

Leilani said something in Hawaiian, quiet and quick, with the tone of someone invoking a specific history. She wasn't talking to them. She was talking to the island.

Or to Cinder.

Maybe both.

"The old stories," she said, to whoever needed to hear it, "say that a sky guardian flies for the people who protect without keeping score."

Cinder looked at the cliff top. At the sky above it. At Elizabeth, at Scarlet, at Leilani, at Max, who had the umbrella raised as if it were a shield, which was either dignity or strategy and possibly both.

He crouched. The wings came out, fully, spanning wider than the beach seemed to have room for, each one catching the sea wind in its own time.

Then he launched.

Not the tentative, exploratory flight of two weeks ago in the forest. This was something different — fast, vertical, deliberate, the kind of flight that came from knowing what you were and needing it. He

rose above the cliff line in three wingbeats, the golden fire trailing behind him, and then he turned and came back, hovering above the beach, above the narrow cliff trail, and the collectors came out of the cave entrance and stopped.

They stopped because there was a dragon above them. That was a sufficient reason to stop.

The larger of the two looked up. Then down. Then at the girls, who were standing on the beach not running, which was either incredibly brave or incredibly confident or, from where the collectors were standing, impossible to tell which.

"What—" the man started.

"You should leave," Scarlet said, in the tone she used when she meant it all the way down.

The second collector looked at Cinder, still hovering, still trailing gold. At Max, who had not lowered the umbrella. At Leilani, who was standing in the ankle-deep surge of the incoming tide with the expression of someone who had history with this cliff and this island and was not going to be removed from either by strangers in practical boots.

The first collector looked at the second.

They left.

Cinder landed beside Scarlet and put his head against her hip, and she put her arm over his shoulders, and for a moment none of them said anything. The sea came in around their feet, cold and persistent, the tide doing what tides do.

Elizabeth opened the notebook.

She wrote one word.

Victory.

Then, below it, because the notebook was also a record: "Cinder flew in combat. Not aggressive, not defensive in the old sense. Protective. There is a difference and it matters."

Fire Hill

The blue sand harness had hardened overnight.

It sat on the desk in their villa room in the morning, the shape of it preserved in the same way coral preserves the shape of what it builds around — not fragile, not merely decorative. When Elizabeth touched it, it was warm, and lighter than it looked, and the blue of it had deepened overnight to the specific blue of the vase, of the note, of the compass housing.

"It's real," Scarlet said.

"It was real last night," Elizabeth said.

"Last night it was sand. Now it's..." Scarlet held it up. The light came through the window and the harness caught it in a way that stone didn't, with a quality that was more like glass. "Now it's the right thing."

Max had the plan before breakfast. He always had the plan before breakfast. "Northern approach to Pu'u Ahi. The park service maintains the main crater road. The northern trail is not maintained by the park service, which means it is maintained by someone else, which means there is a someone else and we should meet them." He accepted the harness from Scarlet and turned it in his hands. "Cinder wears this. The old carvings suggest the guardian gear has a function beyond aesthetics."

"What function?" Elizabeth asked.

"I don't know yet," Max said, which was the honest answer.

* * *

The trail to Fire Hill began where the tourist path ended and the park service's very clear signage became diplomatically vague. Leilani led them — it was her island, and she moved through it the way Elizabeth moved through the castle corridors, not thinking about direction, just being where she meant to be. The lava rock underfoot was old enough to have grown a skin of lichen and sparse grass, and the trees here were different from the coastal vegetation — lower, denser, the landscape turned more toward sky the higher they went.

Cinder wore the harness.

He had accepted it the way he accepted most things from this specific group of people: with a brief and evaluating examination, one tentative sniff, and then a stillness while it was fitted, a stillness that was not submission but cooperation, the distinction being that one required trust and one didn't. He wore it the way it was designed — the chest piece forward, the wing bands clear of the joint, the tail coupler loose enough for full range — and when it was on, something about him changed, very slightly. He stood slightly differently. His head came up.

"He knows what it means," Leilani said.

"He knows what he is," Scarlet said.

The crater rim was wider than Elizabeth had expected, the interior long since cooled to a bowl of dark rock that had, in the time since it was volcanic, grown its own small ecology. And at the center, in a ring of old stones that had been placed rather than tumbled there, was a pedestal.

Stone, ancient, the kind of grey that came from being outside for centuries in all weather. And on it, in a small carved cavity: a single key of blue glass.

Elizabeth stared at it.

"The last map piece," Scarlet said.

"The last map piece," Elizabeth confirmed.

She looked at the glass. At the pedestal. At the placement of the stones around it — not decorative, she thought. Significant. Oriented toward the cardinal directions in a way that wasn't accidental.

"Someone put this here. Deliberately. A long time ago."

"Who built the vase?" Scarlet asked. It was the question they'd been carrying since the Clocktower.

"The same person who built all of it," Max said, from behind them, and his voice had in it something that was either reverence or sadness or both. "Someone who knew that the guardians were real and that they would come back someday, and built a system to help the people who found them. A test and a map and a record, all at once."

He paused.

"The castle records call it the Dragon Glass," he said. "The records go back to a maker I've never been able to identify. The Glass was supposed to go to someone ready for it. Someone who broke things and fixed them. Someone who told the truth even when it was difficult." He looked at both of them. "I did not design the test, Princesses. I only kept the door unlocked."

Cinder hummed.

On the stone walls of the crater's interior, something began to appear — not Echo-Vision exactly, but the same principle. Dragons in flight, over this island, over the ocean, over a kingdom that the girls recognized from their own windows. The pattern of where they had lived and nested and been. The places where the blue glass was buried, each one lighting up in sequence, until the whole map was visible: Crystal Cave, the Clocktower, Fire Hill, and several others they hadn't found yet, placed on a network that crossed oceans.

Then all the lights found the pedestal.

And from the pedestal, the final key.

Elizabeth picked it up. It was warm. She held it in her palm beside the compass, and in the full afternoon sunlight of the volcano crater, the frosted letters inside the key were visible immediately: THE CIRCLE IS COMPLETE. And below that, just one word: HOME.

Behind them, the mechanical bird crossed the crater rim once, too high to reach and too deliberate to be lost. The Silver Net had retreated, not disappeared.

Cinder breathed a small golden flame onto the center stone, and for one long moment the lava beneath it glowed warm amber, as if remembering.

"Does this mean there are more eggs?" Scarlet asked.

"Perhaps," Max said. "That depends on many things we don't know yet."

"But possibly more eggs."

"Possibly more eggs," Max allowed.

Leilani was looking at the crater, at the map still faintly visible on the stone walls. "The sky guardians were here for a long time," she said. "Then they weren't. Then they are again." She looked at Cinder, who was watching the map with the interested calm of someone reading their own history. "The stories said they'd come back when the world was ready."

"Or when someone specific was ready," Elizabeth said.

She took out the notebook. She found the last entry — one word, Victory — and wrote below it, carefully, in the small handwriting she used when she was trying to be precise:

The map is complete. The record is whole. The circle closes. Something is beginning.

She left the last page blank.

Not because there was nothing to write. Because some chapters needed space before you started them.

The Sky Guardian Promise

Back at the castle, the vase stood on its pedestal.

The vase stood on its pedestal, which was where it had always stood, and in the morning light from the Great Hall's stained glass windows it was different from what it had been before — better, many people said, though they couldn't have explained precisely why. The gold veins had settled into the glass in the months since the repair, and in the right light the roses painted on the outside seemed to be lit from within the lines rather than just on the surface.

Dad stood looking at it most mornings when he passed through. He never said anything. He didn't need to.

The Ladybug Room door sign had been updated over the Hawaii trip. Max had done it on the flight home, arriving at their door the morning after they landed with new signage — the same dark wood, the same gold letters, but now reading:

ROYAL DETECTIVE HEADQUARTERS

Field Office: Crystal Cave and environs Associate Office: Whispering Tides, Hawaii

And below it, in Leilani's handwriting, on a card she'd sent with a pressed sea-glass fragment and a dried flower from the crater trail:

The sky guardians remember everyone who keeps faith with them. — L.

Pinned beside it was a smaller note in purple ink, delivered through the school office and addressed only to Royal Detective Headquarters.

Keep paying attention between the lines. Some maps are written there. — Mrs. Rosie

Cinder was growing.

They measured him monthly now — not because Max required data, though Max appreciated it, but because the measurements were satisfying the way all records were satisfying, the evidence that something was moving forward. He came to the castle one day a week on what had evolved into a structured arrangement: Max opened the east garden door at dusk, and Cinder came in under the fog he'd learned to produce specifically for this purpose, moving through the castle gardens with the confident unhurried stride of a creature who belonged where he was going. He spent the night in the east garden turret Max had quietly repurposed, and left before dawn.

The rest of the time he was in the cave, practicing things that now had names — Echo-Vision, mist-seal, the specific fire calibration that could heat milk without scorching and light a dark passage without burning anything nearby. He practiced the harness, which Max had established was designed to carry objects at altitude, and which Cinder wore now the way you wore something that fit you exactly right.

Leilani had come to the castle for a month, the previous autumn. She'd slept in the Ladybug Room on a cot they'd set up beside the bunk bed, and she and Scarlet had talked until far too late every night and Elizabeth had listened and added things and written everything important in the notebook. She'd gone back home knowing things and leaving behind things, which was how friendship worked when it was real.

She'd promised to come back.

* * *

It was a Saturday morning in early spring, nothing particular about it, when Scarlet appeared downstairs with a stone in her hand and the expression that Elizabeth had long since learned to read as: something is starting.

"I found something," Scarlet said.

"Found or investigated?"

"Found by investigating."

"That's called investigating."

"It's called a head start." Scarlet set the stone on the breakfast table. It was smooth and rounded, the pale grey of garden stones, unremarkable from any angle except the one where you held it in direct morning sunlight and looked at the center of it.

Where the light entered, something glimmered.

Three letters, frosted into the stone the way the letters had been frosted into the glass. Not from the vase — the vase was whole now, accounted for. This was something else, something new, and the letters were:

MAP.

Elizabeth set down her orange juice.

Her hand was already moving toward the notebook, already finding the next blank page, already uncapping the pen.

From the window behind them, a shape moved across the morning sky — low, golden, trailing a breath of warm mist, following the line of the garden wall toward the Whispering Woods. Not a bird. Not a machine. Cinder, doing his morning circuit, checking on the world he had taken into his care.

He circled the garden once. Then he turned and pointed himself at the woods, and his wings found the rhythm of something that knew where it was going.

Elizabeth finished the case number at the top of the new page.

Beside her, Scarlet was already pulling on her adventure boots, the ones with the laces she'd never learned to double-knot and Elizabeth always fixed for her, because some things were easier to do for each other than to do alone.

"Ready?" Scarlet asked.

Elizabeth looked at the window. At the stone. At the notebook, open and waiting.

"Yes," she said.

She always was.